

DFS Templates

DFS appears in five forms. The pattern determines naming, return type, and where the answer is built.

When to Use — Signal → Pattern

Problem signal phrase	Pattern / template
"height / depth / sum OF the subtree", combine results upward	#1 Process children first, combine at node (post-order)
"root-to-leaf path", "number built along the path"	#2 Process node first, pass state down (pre-order)
"longest/best path that may bend through a node" (spans both arms)	#3 Tree global answer
"count islands / largest region / flood fill" on a grid	#4 Grid DFS
"can finish all", "detect cycle", "valid course order" (directed)	#5 Graph DFS 3-color
"all subsets / permutations / combinations", "find every way"	#6 Backtracking
"valid BST", "kth smallest", "closest value", "successor"	BST templates (pass bounds / inorder / binary search)

Quick Reference Table

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
104	Maximum Depth of Binary Tree	Maximum number of nodes along the longest root-to-leaf path.	my depth is just one more than my deeper child's depth.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
543	Diameter of Binary Tree	Length of the longest path between any two nodes (path does not need to pass through root).	the longest path bends at some node using both arms, but only one arm can extend to its parent.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
124	Binary Tree Maximum Path Sum	Maximum sum of any path between any two nodes. Values can be negative.	a negative arm is worse than taking nothing, so clamp it to 0 before adding.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
110	Balanced Binary Tree	Is every node's left and right subtree within 1 height of each other?	fold "is it balanced" into the height return — a poisoned -1 bubbles up and stops the work.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
226	Invert Binary Tree	Mirror a binary tree — swap left and right subtrees at every node.	invert both children, then swap the pointers at this node.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
112	Path Sum	Does any root-to-leaf path sum to <code>targetSum</code> ?	subtract each node from the target on the way down; a leaf with remaining 0 is a hit.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
113	Path Sum II	Return all root-to-leaf paths that sum to <code>targetSum</code> .	the same <code>path</code> list is reused for every branch, so undo your add as you unwind.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$ for output paths	Standard
257	Binary Tree Paths	Return all root-to-leaf paths as strings (" <code>1→2→5</code> ").	append to a shared <code>StringBuilder</code> , then truncate back to your entry length to undo.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$ for output paths	Standard
129	Sum Root to Leaf Numbers	Each root-to-leaf path represents a number (e.g., $1→2→3 = 123$). Return the total sum.	build the number digit by digit on the way down (<code>current*10 + val</code>); add it up at each leaf.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
200	Number of Islands	Count the number of islands (connected groups of ' <code>1</code> ') in a binary grid.	each unvisited land cell starts a new island; flood-fill sinks the whole island so it's counted once.	$O(m \cdot n)$	$O(m \cdot n)$	Standard
695	Max Area of Island	Return the area of the largest island.	an island's area is 1 (this cell) plus the areas its four neighbors flood back.	$O(m \cdot n)$	$O(m \cdot n)$	Standard
207	Course Schedule	Can you finish all courses given prerequisites? Return false if there is a cycle.	re-entering a node still on the current DFS stack means you looped back to a prerequisite → cycle.	$O(V+E)$	$O(V+E)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
210	Course Schedule II	Return a valid order to take all courses. Return <code>[]</code> if a cycle exists.	a node finishes only after all it depends on do, so post-order reversed is a valid prerequisite order.	$O(V+E)$	$O(V+E)$	Standard
46	Permutations	All permutations of distinct integers.	order matters, so every position considers all unused elements (no <code>start</code> index).	$O(n \cdot n!)$	$O(n)$	Standard
78	Subsets	All subsets (power set) of distinct integers.	every prefix on the way down is itself a valid subset, so record at every node.	$O(n \cdot 2^n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
39	Combination Sum	All combinations summing to target. Same element may be used unlimited times. No duplicate combos.	passing <code>i</code> (not <code>i+1</code>) lets you pick the same element again; <code>start</code> still forbids going backward, so no reordered dups.	$O(n \cdot 2^n)$	$O(\text{target}/\text{min})$	Standard
40	Combination Sum II	Each element used at most once. Input may have duplicates. No duplicate combos in output.	after sorting, equal values sit together; skipping a repeat at the <i>same level</i> prevents producing the same combo twice.	$O(n \cdot 2^n)$	$O(\text{target}/\text{min})$	Standard
79	Word Search	Given a board of characters, return true if the word exists as a connected path (no cell reused).	the grid itself is the state — temporarily blank a cell so the same path can't reuse it, then restore on the way back.	$O(m \cdot n \cdot 4^L)$ where $L = \text{word length}$	$O(L)$	Standard
131	Palindrome Partitioning	Partition string <code>s</code> such that every substring is a palindrome. Return all such partitions.	try every prefix as the first cut; only recurse on the rest when that prefix is a palindrome.	$O(n \cdot 2^n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
98	Validate Binary Search Tree	Determine if a binary tree is a valid BST. Each node's value must be strictly greater than all values in its left subtree and strictly less than all values in its right subtree.		$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Pass min/max bounds down — each call tightens the valid range. Use <code>long</code> to handle <code>Integer.MIN_VALUE</code> and <code>Integer.MAX_VALUE</code> edge cases.
230	Kth Smallest Element in a BST	Find the kth smallest element in a BST (1-indexed).		$O(k)$ average, $O(n)$ worst	$O(h)$	BST inorder traversal visits nodes in ascending order. Count nodes visited; when count reaches k , record the answer and stop early.

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
270	Closest Binary Search Tree Value	Given a BST and a <code>target</code> (double), return the value in the BST closest to target.		$O(h)$	$O(1)$	Use BST structure to navigate in $O(h)$. At each node, compare distance to closest seen so far, then binary-search left or right.
285	Inorder Successor in BST	Given a node <code>p</code> in a BST, return its inorder successor (the smallest node with value greater than <code>p.val</code>). Return null if no such node exists.		$O(h)$	$O(1)$	Navigate the BST. When <code>root.val > p.val</code> , this root is a candidate — save it and go left (to find a smaller valid candidate). When <code>root.val <= p.val</code> , go right (must find something larger).
687	Longest Univalue Path	Return the length of the longest path in a binary tree where every node along the path has the same value. The path does not need to pass through the root.		$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Post-order DFS. At each node, extend the left or right path only if the child's value matches. The path through the current node = leftPath + rightPath. Return the max single-direction extension upward.
37	Sudoku Solver	Fill a partially filled 9×9 Sudoku so every row, column, and 3×3 box contains digits 1-9.		$O(9^m)$ m =empty cells	$O(1)$	backtracking that tries digits 1-9 in each empty cell, validating against row, column, and box constraints before recursing.
47	Permutations II	Return all unique permutations of an array that may contain duplicates.		$O(n \cdot n!)$	$O(n)$	sort first; use a <code>used[]</code> array; skip a value if the previous equal value at the same tree level has not been used (prevents duplicate permutations).
51	N-Queens	Place n queens on an $n \times n$ board so no two attack each other; return all distinct solutions.		$O(n!)$	$O(n)$	backtrack row by row; track occupied columns and both diagonals. Cells on the same \ diagonal share $r - c$; cells on the same / diagonal share $r + c$.
60	Permutation Sequence	Return the k th permutation (1-indexed) of the sequence 1.. n .		$O(n^2)$	$O(n)$	no backtracking — use the factorial number system. Each position's digit is determined directly by $(k-1) / (\text{remaining}-1)!$.
90	Subsets II	Return all possible unique subsets of an array that may contain duplicates.		$O(n \cdot 2^n)$	$O(n)$	sort first; within a recursion level, skip a value equal to its predecessor to avoid duplicate subsets.
216	Combination Sum III	Find all combinations of k numbers from 1-9 (each used at most once) that sum to n .		$O(C(9, k))$	$O(k)$	standard combination backtracking with start index $i+1$ (no reuse), but with two stopping constraints — count and remaining sum.
549	Binary Tree Longest Consecutive Sequence II	Find the length of the longest consecutive path in a binary tree. The path can be increasing or decreasing and may		$O(n)$	$O(h)$	post-order DFS returns a pair <code>{increasing, decreasing}</code> for each node. A path through the node combines an increasing run

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
		go through a node (child-parent-child).				from one child with a decreasing run from the other.
17	Letter Combinations of a Phone Number	Given a string of digits 2-9, return all letter combinations the phone keypad could represent.	backtrack one digit at a time, appending each candidate letter and undoing it.	$O(4^n \cdot n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
22	Generate Parentheses	Generate all combinations of n pairs of well-formed parentheses.	add (while opens remain; add) only while closes outstanding; backtrack each choice.	$O(4^n / \sqrt{n})$	$O(n)$	Standard
36	Valid Sudoku	Determine if a filled-in 9x9 Sudoku board is valid (no repeats in any row, column, or 3x3 box).	encode each digit's row/column/box membership into a HashSet of unique keys; a collision means invalid.	$O(1)$ (fixed 81 cells)	$O(1)$	Standard
77	Combinations	Return all combinations of k numbers chosen from 1 to n.	standard backtracking with start index advancing to i+1; record when path reaches size k.	$O(k \cdot C(n, k))$	$O(k)$	Standard
93	Restore IP Addresses	Return all valid IP addresses formable by inserting dots into a digit string.	backtrack choosing 1-3 digit segments; each segment must be 0-255 and have no leading zero.	$O(1)$ (bounded branching)	$O(1)$	Standard
94	Binary Tree Inorder Traversal	Return the inorder traversal (left → root → right) of a binary tree.	recurse left, visit node, recurse right.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
95	Unique Binary Search Trees II	Generate all structurally unique BSTs storing values 1..n.	pick each value as root; recursively build all left subtrees from the smaller range and all right subtrees from the larger range, then combine.	$O(n \cdot \text{Catalan}(n))$	$O(n \cdot \text{Catalan}(n))$	Standard
99	Recover Binary Search Tree	Two nodes of a BST were swapped by mistake; recover the tree without changing its structure.	an inorder traversal of a valid BST is ascending; the swapped pair shows up as one or two descents. Track them and swap their values.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
100	Same Tree	Check if two binary trees are structurally identical with the same node values.	both null is equal; one null or differing values is not; otherwise recurse on both children.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
101	Symmetric Tree	Check if a binary tree is a mirror image of itself.	compare the outer pairs and inner pairs of two mirrored subtrees.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
102	Binary Tree Level Order Traversal	Return node values level by level, left to	BFS with a queue; drain one level's worth	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
		right.	of nodes per outer iteration.			
103	Binary Tree Zigzag Level Order Traversal	Return node values level by level, alternating left-to-right and right-to-left.	standard BFS, but reverse the level list on alternate levels.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
105	Construct Binary Tree from Preorder and Inorder Traversal	Reconstruct a binary tree from its preorder and inorder traversals.	the first preorder element is the root; its position in inorder splits left/right subtree sizes.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
106	Construct Binary Tree from Inorder and Postorder Traversal	Reconstruct a binary tree from its inorder and postorder traversals.	the last postorder element is the root; build right subtree before left since postorder is consumed back to front.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
107	Binary Tree Level Order Traversal II	Return node values level by level, from bottom to top.	standard BFS, then reverse the list of levels.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
108	Convert Sorted Array to Binary Search Tree	Convert a sorted array to a height-balanced BST.	pick the middle element as the root so left and right halves are balanced; recurse on each half.	$O(n)$	$O(\log n)$	Standard
111	Minimum Depth of Binary Tree	Find the shortest path length from root to any leaf.	like max depth, but a node with one missing child must take the existing child's depth (a non-leaf cannot end a root-to-leaf path).	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	skip the null side
114	Flatten Binary Tree to Linked List	Flatten a binary tree into a right-pointer linked list following preorder, in place.	reverse-preorder traversal (right, left, node) lets you prepend each node to a running tail.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
116	Populating Next Right Pointers in Each Node	Connect each node's <code>next</code> pointer to its right neighbor in a perfect binary tree, using $O(1)$ extra space.	use already-established <code>next</code> links of the current level to thread the next level.	$O(n)$	$O(1)$	Standard
117	Populating Next Right Pointers in Each Node II	Same as #116 but for an arbitrary binary tree.	walk each level via <code>next</code> links, building the next level's chain through a dummy head since children may be missing.	$O(n)$	$O(1)$	Standard
144	Binary Tree Preorder Traversal	Return the preorder traversal (root $\rightarrow$ left $\rightarrow$ right) of a binary tree.	visit node, recurse left, recurse right.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
145	Binary Tree Postorder Traversal	Return the postorder traversal (left $\rightarrow$ right)	recurse left, recurse right, visit node.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
		→ root) of a binary tree.				
199	Binary Tree Right Side View	Return the values visible from the right side, one per level.	BFS each level; the last node dequeued in a level is the rightmost visible one.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
222	Count Complete Tree Nodes	Count nodes in a complete binary tree faster than $O(n)$.	if leftmost and rightmost depths match, the subtree is perfect ($2^h - 1$ nodes); otherwise recurse on both children.	$O(\log^2 n)$	$O(\log n)$	perfect subtree shortcut
235	Lowest Common Ancestor of a Binary Search Tree	Find the LCA of two nodes in a BST.	if both values are less than the node, go left; if both greater, go right; otherwise the node is the split point = LCA.	$O(h)$	$O(1)$	Standard
236	Lowest Common Ancestor of a Binary Tree	Find the LCA of two nodes in a general binary tree.	post-order: if p or q matches the node, return it; the node where both arms return non-null is the LCA.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
241	Different Ways to Add Parentheses	Compute all results obtainable by parenthesizing an expression differently.	at each operator, split into left and right subexpressions, recursively evaluate both, and combine every pair.	$O(\text{Catalan}(n))$	$O(\text{Catalan}(n))$	Standard
250	Count Unival Subtrees	Count subtrees in which all nodes share the same value.	post-order; a subtree is unival if both children are unival and their values match the node's value.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
255	Verify Preorder Sequence in Binary Search Tree	Verify whether an array is a valid BST preorder traversal.	use a stack to simulate the path; popping when a value exceeds the top sets a lower bound. Any later value below that bound is invalid.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
267	Palindrome Permutation II	Return all palindrome permutations of a string.	a palindrome needs at most one odd-count character; build half the palindrome by permuting half the characters, then mirror it.	$O((n/2)!)$	$O(n)$	Standard
272	Closest Binary Search Tree Value II	Find the k values in a BST closest to a target.	inorder gives sorted values; keep a sliding window of size k, evicting the farther end while a closer candidate exists.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	values only get farther, stop early

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
282	Expression Add Operators	Insert +, -, * between digits of a string to reach a target value; return all expressions.	backtrack each operand prefix; track running value and the last multiplied term so * can fold correctly.	$O(4^n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
291	Word Pattern II	Check if a string follows a pattern where each pattern char maps to a non-empty, non-overlapping substring.	backtrack assigning substrings to pattern characters, enforcing a bijection via two maps.	$O(\text{exponential})$	$O(n)$	Standard
293	Flip Game	Given a string of '+' and '-', return all states after flipping one "++" to "--".	scan for each "++" occurrence and produce the flipped string.	$O(n^2)$	$O(n)$	Standard
294	Flip Game II	Determine if the first player can guarantee a win in Flip Game.	the current player wins if any "++" flip leaves the opponent in a losing position; memoize states.	$O(\text{exponential, memoized})$	$O(\text{states})$	Standard
297	Serialize and Deserialize Binary Tree	Serialize a binary tree to a string and deserialize it back.	preorder with explicit "#" null markers uniquely encodes structure; rebuild by consuming tokens in the same order.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
298	Binary Tree Longest Consecutive Sequence	Find the longest consecutive increasing-by-1 path going from parent to child.	pass the current run length down; extend it when the child is exactly parent + 1, otherwise reset to 1.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
301	Remove Invalid Parentheses	Remove the minimum number of parentheses to make a string valid; return all distinct results.	BFS by removal count; the first level whose strings include valid ones is the minimum-removal answer.	$O(2^n)$	$O(2^n)$	Standard
306	Additive Number	Check if a string forms an additive sequence (each number is the sum of the two preceding).	backtrack the first two numbers; the rest of the string is forced, so just verify it matches the running sums.	$O(n^3)$	$O(n)$	Standard
314	Binary Tree Vertical Order Traversal	Return node values ordered by column, then by row.	BFS tracking each node's column; collect values per column, then read columns left to right.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
320	Generalized Abbreviation	Return all abbreviations of a word (replace any non-adjacent groups of letters with their counts).	for each character, choose to either abbreviate it (extend a count) or keep it literally; backtrack.	$O(2^n \cdot n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
339	Nested List Weight Sum	Sum each integer in a nested list weighted by its depth.	DFS carrying the current depth; integers add <code>value * depth</code> ,	$O(n)$	$O(d)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
			lists recurse one level deeper.			
364	Nested List Weight Sum II	Sum each integer weighted by its inverse depth (deepest integers have weight 1).	weight = (maxDepth – depth + 1). Accumulate sum of values at each level and a running unweighted total per BFS level so deeper values get counted more often.	O(n)	O(n)	shallow values re-counted each level
386	Lexicographical Numbers	Return integers 1..n in lexicographical order.	DFS a 10-ary prefix tree: start at each digit, append 0-9 as long as the number stays $\leq n$.	O(n)	O(log n)	Standard
404	Sum of Left Leaves	Sum the values of all left leaves in a binary tree.	pass down whether a node is a left child; add its value when it is both a left child and a leaf.	O(n)	O(h)	Standard
426	Convert Binary Search Tree to Sorted Doubly Linked List	Convert a BST into a sorted circular doubly linked list in place.	inorder traversal yields sorted order; link each node to the previous one, then close the ring between head and tail.	O(n)	O(h)	Standard
429	N-ary Tree Level Order Traversal	Return the level order traversal of an N-ary tree.	BFS, enqueueing all children of each node per level.	O(n)	O(n)	Standard
437	Path Sum III	Count downward paths (any node to any descendant) summing to a target.	prefix-sum the running root-to-node sum; the number of paths ending here equals how many earlier prefixes equal <code>current – target</code> .	O(n)	O(n)	prefix-sum count
440	K-th Smallest in Lexicographical Order	Find the kth smallest integer in 1..n by lexicographical order.	count how many numbers share a prefix; skip whole subtrees of the 10-ary prefix tree when k exceeds their size, otherwise descend.	O(log ² n)	O(1)	Standard
449	Serialize and Deserialize BST	Serialize and deserialize a BST compactly.	preorder alone reconstructs a BST using value bounds, so no null markers are needed.	O(n)	O(n)	Standard
450	Delete Node in a BST	Delete a key from a BST and return the new root.	find the node; if it has two children, replace its value with the inorder successor (smallest in right subtree) and delete that successor.	O(h)	O(h)	Standard

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473	Matchsticks to Square	Determine if matchsticks can form a square (4 equal sides) using all sticks.	backtrack placing each stick into one of 4 side buckets; prune when total isn't divisible by 4 or a stick exceeds the side length.	$O(4^n)$	$O(n)$	skip equal buckets
488	Zuma Game	Find the minimum balls from hand to insert to clear the board (or -1).	DFS each board state, trying every hand ball at every insertion point, removing groups of 3+; memoize visited states.	$O(\text{exponential})$	$O(\text{states})$	Standard
489	Robot Room Cleaner	Clean an entire room with a robot that has only relative move/turn/clean APIs and no map.	DFS with backtracking using relative coordinates; clean, try all four directions, and reverse-move to return after each branch.	$O(\text{cells})$	$O(\text{cells})$	Standard
491	Increasing Subsequences	Return all increasing subsequences of length ≥ 2 (input may have duplicates).	backtrack choosing elements $\geq$ the last picked; within one recursion level use a set to skip duplicate starts. Cannot sort (would destroy original order).	$O(2^n \cdot n)$	$O(n)$	skip dup at same level
501	Find Mode in Binary Search Tree	Find the mode(s) (most frequent values) in a BST that may have duplicates.	inorder gives sorted values, so equal values are adjacent; track current run count and update the mode list when counts tie or exceed the max.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
508	Most Frequent Subtree Sum	Find the subtree sum(s) that occur most frequently.	post-order compute each subtree's sum, tally frequencies in a map, then collect the keys with the max frequency.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
510	Inorder Successor in BST II	Find the inorder successor of a node given only a parent pointer (no root).	if a right subtree exists, the successor is its leftmost node; otherwise climb up until you come from a left child.	$O(h)$	$O(1)$	Standard
513	Find Bottom Left Tree Value	Find the leftmost value in the last (deepest) row of a binary tree.	BFS scanning right-to-left so the final node dequeued is the bottom-left value.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
515	Find Largest Value in Each Tree Row	Return the maximum value in each row of a binary tree.	BFS level by level, tracking the max per level.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
526	Beautiful Arrangement	Count permutations of $1..n$ where each number divides or is	backtrack placing numbers position by position, only	$O(k)$ where k = valid arrangements	$O(n)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
		divisible by its position.	choosing a number when it satisfies the divisibility rule.			
536	Construct Binary Tree from String	Build a binary tree from a string like <code>4(2(3)(1))(6(5))</code> .	parse the leading number as the node, then the first parenthesized group as the left subtree and the second as the right subtree.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
538	Convert BST to Greater Tree	Replace each node's value with the sum of all values greater than or equal to it.	reverse inorder (right $\rightarrow$ node $\rightarrow$ left) visits values in descending order; carry a running sum and add it into each node.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
545	Boundary of Binary Tree	Return the boundary: root, left boundary top-down, leaves left-to-right, right boundary bottom-up, no duplicates.	collect three parts separately — left boundary (excluding leaves), all leaves, and right boundary reversed (excluding leaves).	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
559	Maximum Depth of N-ary Tree	Find the maximum depth of an N-ary tree.	depth is 1 plus the max depth among all children.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
563	Binary Tree Tilt	Sum the tilt of every node, where tilt = $ \text{left subtree sum} - \text{right subtree sum} $.	post-order return each subtree sum; accumulate the absolute difference into a global total.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
572	Subtree of Another Tree	Check whether <code>subRoot</code> is a subtree of <code>root</code> .	at every node of <code>root</code> , test for structural equality with <code>subRoot</code> .	$O(m \cdot n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
589	N-ary Tree Preorder Traversal	Return the preorder traversal of an N-ary tree.	visit the node, then recurse into each child in order.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
590	N-ary Tree Postorder Traversal	Return the postorder traversal of an N-ary tree.	recurse into all children first, then visit the node.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
606	Construct String from Binary Tree	Build a preorder string with parentheses, e.g. <code>1(2(4))(3)</code> .	append the value, then each non-null child wrapped in parentheses; keep empty <code>()</code> for a left child only when a right child exists.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
617	Merge Two Binary Trees	Merge two binary trees by summing overlapping node values.	if either node is null, return the other; otherwise sum values and recurse on both child pairs.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
637	Average of Levels in Binary Tree	Return the average value of nodes on each level.	BFS each level, summing values and	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
			dividing by the level size.			
652	Find Duplicate Subtrees	Return one root per group of structurally identical, duplicated subtrees.	serialize each subtree post-order into a canonical string; the second time a serialization appears, record its root.	$O(n^2)$	$O(n^2)$	Standard
653	Two Sum IV - Input is a BST	Find whether two nodes in a BST sum to a target.	traverse, storing seen values in a set; for each node check if <code>target - val</code> was seen.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
654	Maximum Binary Tree	Build a tree where the root is the array max, left subtree from the left subarray, right subtree from the right subarray.	find the max in the range as root, recurse on the two halves.	$O(n^2)$	$O(n)$	Standard
662	Maximum Width of Binary Tree	Return the maximum width of any level, where width counts the gap between the leftmost and rightmost non-null nodes.	assign heap-style indices (left = $2i$, right = $2i+1$); per level the width is last index – first index + 1.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
671	Second Minimum Node In a Binary Tree	In a tree where each node's value is the min of its children, find the second smallest value overall.	the root is the global minimum; DFS for the smallest value strictly greater than the root.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
679	24 Game	Determine if four numbers can be combined with +, –, ×, ÷ to make 24.	backtrack: pick any two numbers, apply each operator, replace them with the result, and recurse until one number remains.	$O(1)$ (bounded)	$O(1)$	Standard
698	Partition to K Equal Sum Subsets	Determine if an array can be split into k subsets of equal sum.	target = total/k; backtrack filling one bucket at a time, sorting descending to fail fast, skipping when total isn't divisible.	$O(k \cdot 2^n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
700	Search in a Binary Search Tree	Find the subtree rooted at the node with a given value in a BST.	binary-search the tree: go left if target is smaller, right if larger.	$O(h)$	$O(1)$	Standard
701	Insert into a Binary Search Tree	Insert a value into a BST and return the root.	descend like a search until reaching a null child, then attach a new node there.	$O(h)$	$O(h)$	Standard
742	Closest Leaf in a Binary Tree	Find the value of the leaf nearest to the node with a given value.	convert the tree to an undirected graph, then BFS from the target node until the first leaf is reached.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
776	Split BST	Split a BST into two trees: one with values $\leq V$ and one with values $> V$.	recurse; at each node decide which result tree it belongs to based on V , then reattach the recursively-split child.	$O(h)$	$O(h)$	Standard
784	Letter Case Permutation	Return all strings formable by toggling the case of letters in a string.	backtrack character by character; digits have one choice, letters branch into lower and upper case.	$O(2^n \cdot n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
814	Binary Tree Pruning	Remove every subtree that contains no node with value 1.	post-order prune children first; drop a node if both children become null and its own value is 0.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
842	Split Array into Fibonacci Sequence	Split a digit string into a Fibonacci-like sequence (each term = sum of previous two), with terms fitting in a 32-bit int.	backtrack the first two numbers; the rest is forced. Prune leading zeros and overflow.	$O(n^2)$	$O(n)$	Standard
863	All Nodes Distance K in Binary Tree	Find all node values exactly distance k from a target node.	build parent links so the tree becomes an undirected graph, then BFS k levels from the target.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
865	Smallest Subtree with all the Deepest Nodes	Find the smallest subtree containing all of the tree's deepest leaves.	post-order return (depth, lca). If left and right depths tie, the current node is the LCA; otherwise carry up the deeper side.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	tie $\rightarrow$ this node is LCA
889	Construct Binary Tree from Preorder and Postorder Traversal	Reconstruct a binary tree from preorder and postorder traversals (any valid tree).	preorder[start] is the root; preorder[start+1] is the left subtree root, whose position in postorder gives the left subtree size.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
897	Increasing Order Search Tree	Rearrange a BST into a right-skewed tree following inorder order.	inorder traversal; relink each node as the right child of the previous, clearing left pointers.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
919	Complete Binary Tree Inserter	Design a structure that supports $O(1)$ insertion into a complete binary tree.	keep a BFS queue of nodes that still have a free child slot; insert into the front node and enqueue the new node.	$O(1)$ insert	$O(n)$	Standard
932	Beautiful Array	Construct an array of $1..n$ where no three indices $i < j < k$ satisfy $2 \cdot a[j] = a[i] + a[k]$.	divide and conquer: a beautiful array of odds followed by evens stays beautiful, since odd + even is never twice an integer.	$O(n \log n)$	$O(n)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
938	Range Sum of BST	Sum all node values within the inclusive range [low, high].	prune branches outside the range using BST ordering.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
951	Flip Equivalent Binary Trees	Check if two trees are flip-equivalent (can be made identical by swapping some children).	match children either directly or swapped at each node.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
958	Check Completeness of a Binary Tree	Determine if a binary tree is complete.	BFS including null children; once a null is seen, no real node may follow.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	real node after a gap
987	Vertical Order Traversal of a Binary Tree	Group node values by column, then by row, then by value within the same position.	DFS recording (col, row, val); sort by column, then row, then value.	$O(n \log n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
988	Smallest String Starting From Leaf	Return the lexicographically smallest root-to-leaf string, where each node maps to a letter 'a'..'z' and the string is read leaf to root.	build the path down, reverse it at each leaf, and track the minimum.	$O(n \cdot h)$	$O(h)$	Standard
993	Cousins in Binary Tree	Check if two values are cousins (same depth, different parents).	BFS recording each value's depth and parent; cousins share depth but differ in parent.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
998	Maximum Binary Tree II	Insert a value into a maximum tree built by appending the value to the original array's end.	since the value was appended last, it lies on the rightmost spine; insert where it first exceeds the current node.	$O(h)$	$O(h)$	Standard
1008	Construct Binary Search Tree from Preorder Traversal	Build a BST from its preorder traversal.	the first value is the root; values less than it form the left subtree, the rest form the right. Use an upper bound to decide where to stop.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
1026	Maximum Difference Between Node and Ancestor	Find the maximum $ a - d $ over all ancestor a and descendant d pairs.	pass the min and max seen on the path down; at each node update the answer with the largest gap against those extremes.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
1038	Binary Search Tree to Greater Sum Tree	Replace each node's value with the sum of all values greater than or equal to it.	reverse inorder (right $\rightarrow$ node $\rightarrow$ left) processes descending order; carry a running sum.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
1087	Brace Expansion	Expand a string with brace options like $\{a, b\}c\{d, e\}$ into	parse each position into a sorted list of choices, then	$O(\text{product of group sizes})$	$O(n)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
		all sorted concatenations.	backtrack the Cartesian product.			
1104	Path In Zigzag Labelled Binary Tree	Return the root-to-node path of labels in a zigzag-labeled infinite binary tree.	the normal parent of label is label/2, but rows alternate direction, so mirror the parent within its row range.	$O(\log n)$	$O(\log n)$	mirror then halve
1110	Delete Nodes And Return Forest	Delete the given values and return the roots of the resulting forest.	post-order; if a node is deleted, its surviving children become new roots. A node is a root if its parent was deleted (or it's the original root) and it itself survives.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
1123	Lowest Common Ancestor of Deepest Leaves	Find the LCA of all the deepest leaves.	post-order return (depth, lca); when both arms reach equal depth, the node is the LCA, else carry up the deeper arm.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard
1161	Maximum Level Sum of a Binary Tree	Return the 1-indexed level with the largest sum of node values.	BFS level by level, tracking the level whose sum is maximum.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
1214	Two Sum BSTs	Given two BSTs and a target, decide if a value from each sums to the target.	store all values of the first BST in a set, then traverse the second checking for the complement.	$O(m + n)$	$O(m)$	Standard
1305	All Elements in Two Binary Search Trees	Return all elements from two BSTs in sorted order.	inorder each tree into a sorted list, then merge the two lists like merge sort.	$O(m + n)$	$O(m + n)$	Standard
1361	Validate Binary Tree Nodes	Given child arrays, verify the nodes form exactly one valid binary tree.	exactly one node has no parent (the root); every other node has exactly one parent, there are no cycles, and all nodes are reachable from the root.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
1382	Balance a Binary Search Tree	Rebuild a BST so it becomes height-balanced.	inorder gives a sorted array; build a balanced BST by recursively choosing the middle element as root.	$O(n)$	$O(n)$	Standard
1522	Diameter of N-Ary Tree	Find the diameter (longest path between any two nodes) of an N-ary tree.	like binary-tree diameter, but track the two deepest child heights to form the longest path through each node.	$O(n)$	$O(h)$	Standard

#	Name	Description	Intuition	Time	Space	Key Implementation
1644	Lowest Common Ancestor of a Binary Tree II	Find the LCA of two nodes that may not both exist in the tree; return null if either is missing.	standard LCA but count how many of p, q were actually found, so a node returned without seeing both isn't accepted.	O(n)	O(h)	Standard
1650	Lowest Common Ancestor of a Binary Tree III	Find the LCA of two nodes given parent pointers, without root access.	like finding the intersection of two linked lists — walk both pointers up, switching to the other node when one reaches the top; they meet at the LCA.	O(h)	O(1)	Standard

All Templates

Variables: `node` = current tree node · `accumulated / current` = state carried down a path · `answer / global` = best cross-node result · `grid[r][c]` = cell at row `r`, col `c` · `state[node]` = 0 unseen / 1 in-stack / 2 done · `start` = first eligible index · `current` = in-progress candidate · `nums[i]` = element being chosen **Pseudocode:**

```
# 1. post-order (combine children):
if node null: return BASE; left=dfs(left); right=dfs(right); return combine(left,right,node.val)
# 2. pre-order (pass state down):
if node null: return; accumulated+=node.val; if leaf: record; dfs(left,accumulated); dfs(right,accumulated)
# 3. tree global answer:
if node null: return 0; left=max(0,dfs(left)); right=max(0,dfs(right)); answer=max(answer,left+right+node.val)
# 4. grid flood fill:
if out of bounds or not TARGET: return; mark VISITED; recurse into 4 neighbors
# 5. graph 3-color cycle:
if state==1: cycle; if state==2: safe; mark in-stack; recurse neighbors (cycle? return); mark done
# 6. backtracking:
if base: record copy; for i from start: skip dups; choose nums[i]; recurse(next); undo
```



```

// 1. PROCESS CHILDREN FIRST, COMBINE AT NODE (post-order)
// each node trusts its children to return a finished answer, then merges them. - WHEN: "what is the h
private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
    if (node == null) return BASE;           // 0 for depth, true for balanced
    int left = dfs(node.left);
    int right = dfs(node.right);
    // combine left, right, node.val → answer propagates up
    return ...;
}

// 2. PROCESS NODE FIRST, PASS STATE DOWN (pre-order)
// carry what you've seen so far down the path; the leaf has the full picture. - WHEN: "root-to-leaf p
private void dfs(TreeNode node, int accumulated) {
    if (node == null) return;
    accumulated += node.val;                 // update state on way down
    if (isLeaf(node)) { /* record */ return; }
    dfs(node.left, accumulated);
    dfs(node.right, accumulated);
    // backtrack: no undo needed for primitive; undo List.add if using collection
}

// 3. TREE - GLOBAL ANSWER (return up the best single arm; update global across both arms)
// the answer may bend through a node using both arms, but only one arm can extend upward. - WHEN: use
int answer = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
    if (node == null) return 0;
    int left = Math.max(0, dfs(node.left)); // clamp negative
    int right = Math.max(0, dfs(node.right));
    answer = Math.max(answer, left + right + node.val); // cross-node path
    return Math.max(left, right) + node.val;           // single arm up
}

// 4. GRID DFS - mark visited by mutating grid; 4-directional flood fill
// stand on a cell, flood into all 4 neighbors, sinking each as you visit it. - WHEN: "connected regio
private void dfs(int[][] grid, int r, int c) {
    if (r < 0 || r >= grid.length || c < 0 || c >= grid[0].length) return;
    if (grid[r][c] != TARGET) return;
    grid[r][c] = VISITED;
    dfs(grid, r+1, c); dfs(grid, r-1, c);
    dfs(grid, r, c+1); dfs(grid, r, c-1);
}

// 5. GRAPH DFS - 3-color visited: 0=unseen 1=in-stack 2=done
// if you re-enter a node still on the current stack, you've looped back → cycle. - WHEN: "can finish
int[] state;
private boolean dfs(int node) {
    if (state[node] == 1) return true; // back edge → cycle
    if (state[node] == 2) return false; // already safe
    state[node] = 1;
    for (int neighbor : graph.get(node))
        if (dfs(neighbor)) return true;
    state[node] = 2;
    return false;
}

// 6. BACKTRACKING - choose / recurse / undo
// build a candidate one element at a time; undo each choice to explore the next branch. - WHEN: "all
private void backtrack(int start, List<Integer> current) {
    if (baseCase) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(current)); return; }
    for (int i = start; i < n; i++) {
        if (skipCondition(i)) continue; // prune duplicates
        current.add(nums[i]);           // choose
        backtrack(i+1, current);        // next = i (reuse) or i+1 (no reuse)
    }
}

```

```
        current.remove(current.size()-1); // undo
    }
}
```

Part 1 — Tree DFS

PROCESS CHILDREN FIRST, COMBINE AT NODE (post-order)

Recurse into children first, then combine results at the current node. Answer propagates upward.

#104 Maximum Depth of Binary Tree

Description: Maximum number of nodes along the longest root-to-leaf path.

Intuition: my depth is just one more than my deeper child's depth.

Variables: `node` = current subtree root · `left / right` = depths of child subtrees **Pseudocode:**

```
maxDepth(root): return dfs(root)
dfs(node):
    if node null: return 0
    left = dfs(node.left)
    right = dfs(node.right)
    return max(left, right) + 1
```

```
class Solution {
    public int maxDepth(TreeNode root) {
        return dfs(root);
    }
    private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        int left = dfs(node.left);
        int right = dfs(node.right);
        return Math.max(left, right) + 1;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#543 Diameter of Binary Tree

Description: Length of the longest path between any two nodes (path does not need to pass through root).

Key: the path through a node = `left height + right height`. Track global max; return only the single best arm up.

Intuition: the longest path bends at some node using both arms, but only one arm can extend to its parent.

Variables: `node` = current subtree root · `left / right` = heights of child subtrees · `diameter` = global longest cross-node path length **Pseudocode:**

```
diameterOfBinaryTree(root): dfs(root); return diameter
dfs(node):
    if node null: return 0
    left = dfs(node.left)
    right = dfs(node.right)
    diameter = max(diameter, left + right) # path bending here
    return max(left, right) + 1          # single arm up
```

```

class Solution {
    int diameter = 0;
    public int diameterOfBinaryTree(TreeNode root) {
        dfs(root);
        return diameter;
    }
    private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        int left = dfs(node.left);
        int right = dfs(node.right);
        diameter = Math.max(diameter, left + right); // cross-node path
        return Math.max(left, right) + 1; // single arm up
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#124 Binary Tree Maximum Path Sum

Description: Maximum sum of any path between any two nodes. Values can be negative.

Key: clamp negative arms to 0 ($\text{Math.max}(0, \dots)$). Global tracks the best $\text{left} + \text{right} + \text{node.val}$; return only $\text{max}(\text{left}, \text{right}) + \text{node.val}$ upward.

Intuition: a negative arm is worse than taking nothing, so clamp it to 0 before adding.

Variables: node = current subtree root · $\text{left} / \text{right}$ = best non-negative arm sums (clamped to 0) · maxSum = global best path sum **Pseudocode:**

```

maxPathSum(root): dfs(root); return maxSum
dfs(node):
    if node null: return 0
    left = max(0, dfs(node.left))
    right = max(0, dfs(node.right))
    maxSum = max(maxSum, left + right + node.val) # path bending here
    return max(left, right) + node.val # single arm up

```

```

class Solution {
    int maxSum = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
    public int maxPathSum(TreeNode root) {
        dfs(root);
        return maxSum;
    }
    private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        int left = Math.max(0, dfs(node.left));
        int right = Math.max(0, dfs(node.right));
        maxSum = Math.max(maxSum, left + right + node.val);
        return Math.max(left, right) + node.val;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#110 Balanced Binary Tree

Description: Is every node's left and right subtree within 1 height of each other?

Key: return -1 as a sentinel for "unbalanced"; short-circuit immediately on -1.

Intuition: fold "is it balanced" into the height return — a poisoned -1 bubbles up and stops the work.

Variables: `node` = current subtree root · `left / right` = child heights, or -1 sentinel meaning unbalanced **Pseudocode:**

```
isBalanced(root): return dfs(root) != -1
dfs(node):
    if node null: return 0
    left = dfs(node.left)
    if left == -1: return -1          # propagate unbalanced
    right = dfs(node.right)
    if right == -1: return -1
    if abs(left - right) > 1: return -1
    return max(left, right) + 1
```

```
class Solution {
    public boolean isBalanced(TreeNode root) {
        return dfs(root) != -1;
    }
    private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        int left = dfs(node.left);
        if (left == -1) return -1;
        int right = dfs(node.right);
        if (right == -1) return -1;
        if (Math.abs(left - right) > 1) return -1;
        return Math.max(left, right) + 1;
    }
}
```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(h)

#226 Invert Binary Tree

Description: Mirror a binary tree — swap left and right subtrees at every node.

Intuition: invert both children, then swap the pointers at this node.

Variables: `root` = current node · `left / right` = already-inverted child subtrees **Pseudocode:**

```
invertTree(root):
    if root null: return null
    left = invertTree(root.left)
    right = invertTree(root.right)
    root.left = right      # swap pointers
    root.right = left
    return root
```

```
class Solution {
    public TreeNode invertTree(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return null;
        TreeNode left = invertTree(root.left);
        TreeNode right = invertTree(root.right);
        root.left = right;
        root.right = left;
        return root;
    }
}
```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(h)

PROCESS NODE FIRST, PASS STATE DOWN (pre-order)

State is built on the way **down** and consumed at leaves. Use backtracking when state is a mutable collection.

#112 Path Sum

Description: Does any root-to-leaf path sum to `targetSum`?

Intuition: subtract each node from the target on the way down; a leaf with remaining 0 is a hit.

Variables: `node` = current node · `remaining` = target minus values seen so far on this path **Pseudocode:**

```
hasPathSum(root, targetSum): return dfs(root, targetSum)
dfs(node, remaining):
  if node null: return false
  remaining -= node.val
  if node is leaf: return remaining == 0
  return dfs(node.left, remaining) OR dfs(node.right, remaining)
```

```
class Solution {
  public boolean hasPathSum(TreeNode root, int targetSum) {
    return dfs(root, targetSum);
  }
  private boolean dfs(TreeNode node, int remaining) {
    if (node == null) return false;
    remaining -= node.val;
    if (node.left == null && node.right == null) return remaining == 0;
    return dfs(node.left, remaining) || dfs(node.right, remaining);
  }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#113 Path Sum II

Description: Return all root-to-leaf paths that sum to `targetSum`.

Key: pass a mutable `path` list down. **Backtrack** (remove last element) after returning from each child.

Intuition: the same `path` list is reused for every branch, so undo your add as you unwind.

Variables: `node` = current node · `remaining` = target minus values seen on this path · `path` = shared list of current root-to-node values · `result` = collected matching paths **Pseudocode:**

```
pathSum(root, targetSum): dfs(root, targetSum, [], result); return result
dfs(node, remaining, path, result):
  if node null: return
  path.add(node.val)
  remaining -= node.val
  if node is leaf and remaining == 0: result.add(copy of path)
  dfs(node.left, remaining, path, result)
  dfs(node.right, remaining, path, result)
  path.remove last      # backtrack
```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> pathSum(TreeNode root, int targetSum) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        dfs(root, targetSum, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, int remaining, List<Integer> path, List<List<Integer>> result) {
        if (node == null) return;
        path.add(node.val);
        remaining -= node.val;
        if (node.left == null && node.right == null && remaining == 0)
            result.add(new ArrayList<>(path));
        dfs(node.left, remaining, path, result);
        dfs(node.right, remaining, path, result);
        path.remove(path.size() - 1); // backtrack
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n) for output paths

#257 Binary Tree Paths

Description: Return all root-to-leaf paths as strings ("1->2->5").

Intuition: append to a shared StringBuilder, then truncate back to your entry length to undo.

Variables: node = current node · path = shared StringBuilder of the current path · len = path length before this node (restore point) · result = collected path strings **Pseudocode:**

```

binaryTreePaths(root): dfs(root, "", result); return result
dfs(node, path, result):
    if node null: return
    len = path.length()
    if len > 0: path.append("->")
    path.append(node.val)
    if node is leaf: result.add(path.toString())
    dfs(node.left, path, result)
    dfs(node.right, path, result)
    path.setLength(len) # backtrack to before this node

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> binaryTreePaths(TreeNode root) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        dfs(root, new StringBuilder(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, StringBuilder path, List<String> result) {
        if (node == null) return;
        int len = path.length();
        if (len > 0) path.append("->");
        path.append(node.val);
        if (node.left == null && node.right == null)
            result.add(path.toString());
        dfs(node.left, path, result);
        dfs(node.right, path, result);
        path.setLength(len); // backtrack to before this node
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n) for output paths

#129 Sum Root to Leaf Numbers

Description: Each root-to-leaf path represents a number (e.g., $1 \rightarrow 2 \rightarrow 3 = 123$). Return the total sum.

Intuition: build the number digit by digit on the way down ($\text{current} * 10 + \text{val}$); add it up at each leaf.

Variables: `node` = current node · `current` = number built from root down to this node **Pseudocode:**

```
sumNumbers(root): return dfs(root, 0)
dfs(node, current):
    if node null: return 0
    current = current * 10 + node.val
    if node is leaf: return current
    return dfs(node.left, current) + dfs(node.right, current)
```

```
class Solution {
    public int sumNumbers(TreeNode root) {
        return dfs(root, 0);
    }
    private int dfs(TreeNode node, int current) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        current = current * 10 + node.val;
        if (node.left == null && node.right == null) return current;
        return dfs(node.left, current) + dfs(node.right, current);
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

543 vs 124 — Side by Side

Both use the global-variable pattern. One difference:

	#543 Diameter	#124 Max Path Sum
Global tracks:	left + right	left + right + node.val
Clamp negatives?	No (heights ≥ 0)	Yes (<code>Math.max(0, ...)</code>)
Return up:	$\max(\text{left}, \text{right}) + 1$	$\max(\text{left}, \text{right}) + \text{node.val}$
Base case:	return 0	return 0

Part 2 — Graph DFS

Grid DFS (4-directional flood fill)

Mark visited by overwriting the cell value. Return the accumulated property (count, area) or void.

#200 Number of Islands

Description: Count the number of islands (connected groups of '1') in a binary grid.

Intuition: each unvisited land cell starts a new island; flood-fill sinks the whole island so it's counted once.

Variables: `grid[r][c]` = cell at row `r`, col `c` ('1' land / '0' water-or-visited) · `count` = number of islands found

Pseudocode:

```

numIslands(grid):
    count = 0
    for each cell (r, c):
        if grid[r][c] == '1': dfs(grid, r, c); count++
    return count
dfs(grid, r, c):
    if (r,c) out of bounds: return
    if grid[r][c] != '1': return
    grid[r][c] = '0'          # mark visited
    recurse into 4 neighbors

```

```

class Solution {
    public int numIslands(char[][] grid) {
        int count = 0;
        for (int r = 0; r < grid.length; r++)
            for (int c = 0; c < grid[0].length; c++)
                if (grid[r][c] == '1') { dfs(grid, r, c); count++; }
        return count;
    }
    private void dfs(char[][] grid, int r, int c) {
        if (r < 0 || r >= grid.length || c < 0 || c >= grid[0].length) return;
        if (grid[r][c] != '1') return;
        grid[r][c] = '0'; // mark visited
        dfs(grid, r+1, c); dfs(grid, r-1, c);
        dfs(grid, r, c+1); dfs(grid, r, c-1);
    }
}

```

Time $O(m \cdot n)$ | **Space** $O(m \cdot n)$

#695 Max Area of Island

Description: Return the area of the largest island.

Key: same flood fill but DFS returns the area of the connected component.

Intuition: an island's area is 1 (this cell) plus the areas its four neighbors flood back.

Variables: `grid[r][c]` = cell at row `r`, col `c` (1 land / 0 water-or-visited) · `max` = largest island area seen

Pseudocode:

```

maxAreaOfIsland(grid):
    max = 0
    for each cell (r, c): max = max(max, dfs(grid, r, c))
    return max
dfs(grid, r, c):
    if (r,c) out of bounds: return 0
    if grid[r][c] != 1: return 0
    grid[r][c] = 0          # mark visited
    return 1 + sum of dfs over 4 neighbors

```



```

class Solution {
    public int maxAreaOfIsland(int[][] grid) {
        int max = 0;
        for (int r = 0; r < grid.length; r++)
            for (int c = 0; c < grid[0].length; c++)
                max = Math.max(max, dfs(grid, r, c));
        return max;
    }
    private int dfs(int[][] grid, int r, int c) {
        if (r < 0 || r >= grid.length || c < 0 || c >= grid[0].length) return 0;
        if (grid[r][c] != 1) return 0;
        grid[r][c] = 0;
        return 1 + dfs(grid, r+1, c) + dfs(grid, r-1, c)
            + dfs(grid, r, c+1) + dfs(grid, r, c-1);
    }
}

```

Time $O(m \cdot n)$ | **Space** $O(m \cdot n)$

Graph DFS — 3-Color Cycle Detection

Three states: `0` = unvisited, `1` = in current DFS stack (visiting), `2` = fully processed (safe).

A back edge (reaching a node with state `1`) means a cycle.

#207 Course Schedule

Description: Can you finish all courses given prerequisites? Return false if there is a cycle.

Intuition: re-entering a node still on the current DFS stack means you looped back to a prerequisite → cycle.

Variables: `state[node]` = 0 unseen / 1 in-stack / 2 done · `graph` = adjacency list (prereq → dependent courses) ·
`node / neighbor` = course indices **Pseudocode:**

```

canFinish(numCourses, prerequisites):
    init state[], build empty graph
    for each [a, b] in prerequisites: graph[b].add(a)
    for each course i: if hasCycle(i): return false
    return true
hasCycle(node):
    if state[node] == 1: return true          # back edge → cycle
    if state[node] == 2: return false        # already safe
    state[node] = 1
    for each neighbor: if hasCycle(neighbor): return true
    state[node] = 2
    return false

```



```

class Solution {
    int[] state;
    List<List<Integer>> graph;
    List<Integer> order;

    public int[] findOrder(int numCourses, int[][] prerequisites) {
        state = new int[numCourses];
        order = new ArrayList<>();
        graph = new ArrayList<>();
        for (int i = 0; i < numCourses; i++) graph.add(new ArrayList<>());
        for (int[] p : prerequisites) graph.get(p[1]).add(p[0]);
        for (int i = 0; i < numCourses; i++)
            if (!dfs(i)) return new int[]{};
        Collections.reverse(order);
        return order.stream().mapToInt(Integer::intValue).toArray();
    }

    private boolean dfs(int node) {
        if (state[node] == 1) return false; // cycle
        if (state[node] == 2) return true; // already done
        state[node] = 1;
        for (int neighbor : graph.get(node))
            if (!dfs(neighbor)) return false;
        state[node] = 2;
        order.add(node); // post-order
        return true;
    }
}

```

Time $O(V+E)$ | **Space** $O(V+E)$

207 vs 210 — Side by Side

	#207 (boolean)	#210 (order)
DFS returns:	boolean (cycle found?)	boolean (cycle found?)
Extra action:	–	order.add(node) after neighbors
Post-process:	–	Collections.reverse(order)

Part 3 — Backtracking

Template: choose → recurse → undo.

`start` controls which elements are eligible at each level. `current` is the in-progress candidate.

Variables: `start` = first eligible index at this level · `current` = in-progress candidate list · `nums[i]` = element being chosen · `result` = collected candidates · `nextStart = i` to reuse element or `i+1` to forbid reuse **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(start, current):
    if base case: result.add(copy of current); return
    for i from start to n-1:
        if skipCondition: continue # prune duplicates
        current.add(nums[i]) # choose
        backtrack(nextStart, current) # nextStart = i (reuse) or i+1 (no reuse)
        current.remove last # undo

```

```
// MENTAL MODEL: grow one candidate by picking an element, recurse, then undo to try the next branch.
private void backtrack(int start, List<Integer> current) {
    if (baseCase) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(current)); return; }
    for (int i = start; i < n; i++) {
        if (skipCondition) continue;
        current.add(nums[i]);           // choose
        backtrack(nextStart, current);  // nextStart = i (reuse) or i+1 (no reuse)
        current.remove(current.size() - 1); // undo
    }
}
```

Backtracking Decision Table

#	All orderings?	Reuse element?	Has duplicates?	Start index	Skip condition
46 Permutations	Yes — used[]	No	No	Loop 0..n, used[i]	used[i]
78 Subsets	No	No	No	start → i+1	None
39 Combination Sum	No	Yes	No	start → i	candidates[i] > remaining
40 Combination Sum II	No	No	Yes	start → i+1	i > start && nums[i] == nums[i-1]
131 Palindrome Part.	No	No	No	start → end	!isPalindrome(sub)

#46 Permutations

Description: All permutations of distinct integers.

Key: loop always from 0; use `boolean[] used` to avoid reusing elements within one permutation.

Intuition: order matters, so every position considers all unused elements (no `start` index).

Variables: `nums` = input array of distinct ints · `used[i]` = whether `nums[i]` is already in current permutation · `current` = permutation being built · `result` = all permutations **Pseudocode:**

```
backtrack(used, current):
    if current has n elements: add copy to result, return
    for each index i in nums:
        if used[i]: skip
        mark i used, append nums[i]
        recurse
        remove last, unmark i
```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> permute(int[] nums) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(nums, new boolean[nums.length], new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int[] nums, boolean[] used, List<Integer> current, List<List<Integer>> result) {
        if (current.size() == nums.length) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(current)); return; }
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            if (used[i]) continue;
            used[i] = true;
            current.add(nums[i]);
            backtrack(nums, used, current, result);
            current.remove(current.size() - 1);
            used[i] = false;
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(n \cdot n!)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#78 Subsets

Description: All subsets (power set) of distinct integers.

Key: record at every node (not just leaves). Pass $i+1$ — each element used at most once, order enforced by `start`.

Intuition: every prefix on the way down is itself a valid subset, so record at every node.

Variables: `nums` = input distinct ints · `start` = first index allowed to pick · `current` = subset being built · `result` = all subsets
Pseudocode:

```

backtrack(start, current):
    record copy of current (every node is a subset)
    for i from start to end:
        append nums[i]
        recurse with start = i+1
    remove last

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> subsets(int[] nums) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(nums, 0, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int[] nums, int start, List<Integer> current, List<List<Integer>> result) {
        result.add(new ArrayList<>(current)); // record every prefix (including empty)
        for (int i = start; i < nums.length; i++) {
            current.add(nums[i]);
            backtrack(nums, i + 1, current, result);
            current.remove(current.size() - 1);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(n \cdot 2^n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#39 Combination Sum

Description: All combinations summing to target. Same element may be used unlimited times. No duplicate combos.

Key: pass `i` (not `i+1`) to allow reuse. Sort + prune when `candidates[i] > remaining`.

Intuition: passing `i` (not `i+1`) lets you pick the same element again; `start` still forbids going backward, so no reordered dups.

Variables: `candidates` = sorted distinct ints · `start` = first index allowed · `remaining` = target minus sum so far · `current` = combo being built · `result` = all combos **Pseudocode:**

```
sort candidates
backtrack(start, remaining, current):
    if remaining == 0: add copy, return
    for i from start to end:
        if candidates[i] > remaining: break (pruning)
        append candidates[i]
        recurse with start = i (allow reuse), remaining - candidates[i]
    remove last
```

```
class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> combinationSum(int[] candidates, int target) {
        Arrays.sort(candidates);
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(candidates, 0, target, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int[] candidates, int start, int remaining, List<Integer> current, List<List<Integer>> result) {
        if (remaining == 0) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(current)); return; }
        for (int i = start; i < candidates.length; i++) {
            if (candidates[i] > remaining) break; // pruning
            current.add(candidates[i]);
            backtrack(candidates, i, remaining - candidates[i], current, result); // i, not i+1
            current.remove(current.size() - 1);
        }
    }
}
```

Time $O(n \cdot 2^n)$ | **Space** $O(\text{target}/\text{min})$

#40 Combination Sum II

Description: Each element used at most once. Input may have duplicates. No duplicate combos in output.

Key: sort first. Skip `candidates[i] == candidates[i-1]` when `i > start` — avoids duplicate combos at the same recursion level. Pass `i+1` — no reuse.

Intuition: after sorting, equal values sit together; skipping a repeat at the *same level* prevents producing the same combo twice.

Variables: `candidates` = sorted ints (may have dups) · `start` = first index allowed · `remaining` = target minus sum so far · `current` = combo being built · `result` = all combos **Pseudocode:**

```

sort candidates
backtrack(start, remaining, current):
    if remaining == 0: add copy, return
    for i from start to end:
        if candidates[i] > remaining: break (pruning)
        if i > start and candidates[i] == candidates[i-1]: skip dup at same level
        append candidates[i]
        recurse with start = i+1 (no reuse), remaining - candidates[i]
        remove last

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> combinationSum2(int[] candidates, int target) {
        Arrays.sort(candidates);
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(candidates, 0, target, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int[] candidates, int start, int remaining, List<Integer> current, List<List<Integer>> result) {
        if (remaining == 0) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(current)); return; }
        for (int i = start; i < candidates.length; i++) {
            if (candidates[i] > remaining) break;
            if (i > start && candidates[i] == candidates[i - 1]) continue; // skip dup at same level
            current.add(candidates[i]);
            backtrack(candidates, i + 1, remaining - candidates[i], current, result); // i+1, no reuse
            current.remove(current.size() - 1);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(n \cdot 2^n)$ | **Space** $O(\text{target}/\text{min})$

#79 Word Search

Description: Given a board of characters, return true if the word exists as a connected path (no cell reused).

Key: mark cell as visited by overwriting, then restore after recursion (backtrack).

Intuition: the grid itself is the state — temporarily blank a cell so the same path can't reuse it, then restore on the way back.

Variables: `board` = grid of chars · `word` = target string · `r`, `c` = current cell · `idx` = index into word being matched · `temp` = saved cell char for restore **Pseudocode:**

```

for each cell (r,c): if dfs(r,c,0) return true
return false

dfs(r, c, idx):
    if idx == word length: return true
    if out of bounds: return false
    if board[r][c] != word[idx]: return false
    save char, blank cell with '#'
    found = dfs any of 4 neighbors with idx+1
    restore char
    return found

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean exist(char[][] board, String word) {
        for (int r = 0; r < board.length; r++)
            for (int c = 0; c < board[0].length; c++)
                if (dfs(board, word, r, c, 0)) return true;
        return false;
    }
    private boolean dfs(char[][] board, String word, int r, int c, int idx) {
        if (idx == word.length()) return true;
        if (r < 0 || r >= board.length || c < 0 || c >= board[0].length) return false;
        if (board[r][c] != word.charAt(idx)) return false;
        char temp = board[r][c];
        board[r][c] = '#'; // mark visited
        boolean found = dfs(board, word, r+1, c, idx+1) || dfs(board, word, r-1, c, idx+1)
            || dfs(board, word, r, c+1, idx+1) || dfs(board, word, r, c-1, idx+1);
        board[r][c] = temp; // restore (backtrack)
        return found;
    }
}

```

Time $O(m \cdot n \cdot 4^L)$ where L = word length | **Space** $O(L)$

#131 Palindrome Partitioning

Description: Partition string `s` such that every substring is a palindrome. Return all such partitions.

Intuition: try every prefix as the first cut; only recurse on the rest when that prefix is a palindrome.

Variables: `s` = input string · `start` = index where next substring begins · `end` = exclusive end of candidate substring · `sub` = `s[start, end)` · `current` = list of palindrome pieces so far · `result` = all partitions **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(start, current):
    if start == length: add copy, return
    for end from start+1 to length:
        sub = s[start, end)
        if sub not palindrome: skip
        append sub
        recurse with start = end
        remove last

isPalindrome(s):
    two pointers i,j move inward; mismatch -> false

```



```

class Solution {
    public List<List<String>> partition(String s) {
        List<List<String>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(s, 0, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(String s, int start, List<String> current, List<List<String>> result) {
        if (start == s.length()) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(current)); return; }
        for (int end = start + 1; end <= s.length(); end++) {
            String sub = s.substring(start, end);
            if (!isPalindrome(sub)) continue;
            current.add(sub);
            backtrack(s, end, current, result);
            current.remove(current.size() - 1);
        }
    }
    private boolean isPalindrome(String s) {
        int i = 0, j = s.length() - 1;
        while (i < j) if (s.charAt(i++) != s.charAt(j--)) return false;
        return true;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n \cdot 2^n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

39 vs 40 — The One Difference

	#39 (reuse OK)	#40 (no reuse, has dups)
Sort:	Yes (pruning)	Yes (both pruning and dup-skip)
Recurse with:	i (same index)	i+1 (next index)
Skip dup line:	—	if (i > start && nums[i] == nums[i-1]) continue

Tree DFS Summary

Pattern	When to use	Answer location
Return up	Combine children at node	return value bubbles up
Pass down	Accumulate state toward leaves	check at leaf
Global variable	Path spans across a node (not up)	int/long field, updated inside dfs

Part — BST (Binary Search Tree) Problems

BST key property: `left subtree values < node.val < right subtree values`. This allows $O(h)$ search/insert/delete by binary-searching the tree.

BST Template: Pass Bounds Down

Variables: `node` = current node · `min / max` = exclusive value bounds valid for this subtree **Pseudocode:**

```

validate(node, min, max):
    if node null: return true
    if node.val <= min OR node.val >= max: return false      # bounds check
    return validate(node.left, min, node.val)               # left tightens max
        AND validate(node.right, node.val, max)           # right tightens min
# call: validate(root, LONG_MIN, LONG_MAX)

```

```

// Validate BST by passing min/max constraints down the tree
boolean validate(TreeNode node, long min, long max) {
    if (node == null) return true;
    if (node.val <= min || node.val >= max) return false;    // ← bounds check
    return validate(node.left, min, node.val)               // left: tighten max
        && validate(node.right, node.val, max);             // right: tighten min
}

// Call with: validate(root, Long.MIN_VALUE, Long.MAX_VALUE)
// Use Long to handle Integer.MIN_VALUE / Integer.MAX_VALUE edge cases

```

BST Template: Inorder Traversal = Sorted Order

Variables: `node` = current node (visited in ascending value order) **Pseudocode:**

```

inorder(node):
    if node null: return
    inorder(node.left)
    process node      # e.g. kth smallest: count, return at k
    inorder(node.right)

```

```

// BST inorder (left → node → right) visits nodes in ascending order
void inorder(TreeNode node) {
    if (node == null) return;
    inorder(node.left);
    // process node (kth smallest: increment counter, return when k)
    inorder(node.right);
}

```

BST Template: Binary Search on Tree

Variables: `root` = current node being examined · `target` = value searched for **Pseudocode:**

```

search(root, target):
    while root not null:
        if root.val == target: return root
        else if root.val < target: root = root.right    # go right
        else: root = root.left                        # go left
    return null

```

```
// Navigate BST like binary search: go left or right based on comparison
TreeNode search(TreeNode root, int target) {
    while (root != null) {
        if (root.val == target) {
            return root;
        } else if (root.val < target) {
            root = root.right;
        } else {
            root = root.left;
        }
    }
    return null;
}
```

#98 Validate Binary Search Tree

Description: Determine if a binary tree is a valid BST. Each node's value must be strictly greater than all values in its left subtree and strictly less than all values in its right subtree.

Variation: Pass min/max bounds down — each call tightens the valid range. Use `long` to handle `Integer.MIN_VALUE` and `Integer.MAX_VALUE` edge cases.

Variables: `root` = tree root · `node` = current node · `min`, `max` = exclusive valid value bounds (as `long`) for this subtree

Pseudocode:

```
return validate(root, -inf, +inf)

validate(node, min, max):
    if node is null: return true
    if node.val <= min or node.val >= max: return false
    return validate(left, min, node.val)
        and validate(right, node.val, max)
```

```
class Solution {
    public boolean isValidBST(TreeNode root) {
        return validate(root, Long.MIN_VALUE, Long.MAX_VALUE);
    }

    private boolean validate(TreeNode node, long min, long max) {
        if (node == null) return true;
        if (node.val <= min || node.val >= max) return false; // ← VARIATION: bounds constraint
        return validate(node.left, min, node.val)           // ← VARIATION: tighten max going left
            && validate(node.right, node.val, max);          // ← VARIATION: tighten min going right
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#230 Kth Smallest Element in a BST

Description: Find the kth smallest element in a BST (1-indexed).

Variation: BST inorder traversal visits nodes in ascending order. Count nodes visited; when count reaches k, record the answer and stop early.

Variables: `root` = tree root · `k` = target rank (1-indexed) · `count` = nodes visited so far in inorder · `result` = value of kth node · `node` = current node

Pseudocode:

```
inorder(root, k); return result
```

```
inorder(node, k):  
    if node is null: return  
    inorder(left, k)  
    count++; if count == k: result = node.val, return  
    inorder(right, k)
```

```
class Solution {  
    private int count = 0, result = 0;  
  
    public int kthSmallest(TreeNode root, int k) {  
        inorder(root, k);  
        return result;  
    }  
  
    private void inorder(TreeNode node, int k) {  
        if (node == null) return;  
        inorder(node.left, k);  
        if (++count == k) { result = node.val; return; } // ← VARIATION: stop at kth node  
        inorder(node.right, k);  
    }  
}
```

Time $O(k)$ average, $O(n)$ worst | **Space** $O(h)$

#270 Closest Binary Search Tree Value

Description: Given a BST and a `target` (double), return the value in the BST closest to target.

Variation: Use BST structure to navigate in $O(h)$. At each node, compare distance to closest seen so far, then binary-search left or right.

Variables: `root` = tree root / current node · `target` = double to approach · `closest` = best value seen so far

Pseudocode:

```
closest = root.val  
while root not null:  
    if |root.val - target| < |closest - target|: closest = root.val  
    go right if root.val < target else go left  
return closest
```

```
class Solution {  
    public int closestValue(TreeNode root, double target) {  
        int closest = root.val;  
        while (root != null) {  
            if (Math.abs(root.val - target) < Math.abs(closest - target))  
                closest = root.val; // ← VARIATION: track closest during search  
            root = root.val < target ? root.right : root.left; // ← VARIATION: binary search  
        }  
        return closest;  
    }  
}
```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(1)$

#285 Inorder Successor in BST

Description: Given a node `p` in a BST, return its inorder successor (the smallest node with value greater than `p.val`). Return null if no such node exists.

Variation: Navigate the BST. When `root.val > p.val`, this root is a candidate — save it and go left (to find a smaller valid candidate). When `root.val <= p.val`, go right (must find something larger).

Variables: `root` = tree root / current node · `p` = node whose successor we want · `result` = best candidate (smallest value > `p.val`) so far **Pseudocode:**

```
result = null
while root not null:
    if root.val > p.val: result = root; go left (seek closer)
    else: go right (need larger)
return result
```

```
class Solution {
    public TreeNode inorderSuccessor(TreeNode root, TreeNode p) {
        TreeNode result = null;
        while (root != null) {
            if (root.val > p.val) {
                result = root;           // ← VARIATION: save as candidate, then search left for closer
                root = root.left;
            } else {
                root = root.right;       // ← VARIATION: must go right to find something > p
            }
        }
        return result;
    }
}
```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(1)$

#687 Longest Univalue Path

Description: Return the length of the longest path in a binary tree where every node along the path has the same value. The path does not need to pass through the root.

Variation: Post-order DFS. At each node, extend the left or right path only if the child's value matches. The path through the current node = `leftPath` + `rightPath`. Return the max single-direction extension upward.

Variables: `root` = tree root · `node` = current node · `max` = global longest univalue path (edge count) · `left`, `right` = child dfs results · `leftPath`, `rightPath` = matching-value extension toward each child **Pseudocode:**

```
dfs(root); return max

dfs(node):
    if node is null: return 0
    left = dfs(node.left); right = dfs(node.right)
    leftPath = left+1 if left child exists and equals node.val else 0
    rightPath = right+1 if right child exists and equals node.val else 0
    max = max(max, leftPath + rightPath)    // path through node
    return max(leftPath, rightPath)        // single direction up
```

```

class Solution {
    private int max = 0;

    public int longestUnivaluePath(TreeNode root) {
        dfs(root);
        return max;
    }

    private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        int left = dfs(node.left);
        int right = dfs(node.right);
        int leftPath = (node.left != null && node.left.val == node.val) ? left + 1 : 0; // ← VARIA
        int rightPath = (node.right != null && node.right.val == node.val) ? right + 1 : 0; // ← VARIA
        max = Math.max(max, leftPath + rightPath); // ← path through this node
        return Math.max(leftPath, rightPath); // ← return max single direction up
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#37 Sudoku Solver

Description: Fill a partially filled 9×9 Sudoku so every row, column, and 3×3 box contains digits 1-9. **Variation:** backtracking that tries digits 1-9 in each empty cell, validating against row, column, and box constraints before recursing.

Variables: `board` = 9x9 grid · `i, j` = current cell · `c` = digit being tried · `row, col` = cell coords in `isValid`

Pseudocode:

```

solve(board):
    for each cell (i,j):
        if cell empty:
            for c from '1' to '9':
                if isValid(board,i,j,c):
                    place c
                    if solve(board): return true
                    erase c (backtrack)
            return false // no digit fits
    return true // all filled

isValid(board, row, col, c):
    for i in 0..8:
        if c in row, in column, or in 3x3 box: return false
    return true

```

```

class Solution {
    public void solveSudoku(char[][] board) { solve(board); }
    private boolean solve(char[][] board) {
        for (int i = 0; i < 9; i++)
            for (int j = 0; j < 9; j++)
                if (board[i][j] == '.') {
                    for (char c = '1'; c <= '9'; c++) {
                        if (isValid(board, i, j, c)) { // ← VARIATION: validate row/col/box
                            board[i][j] = c;
                            if (solve(board)) return true;
                            board[i][j] = '.'; // backtrack
                        }
                    }
                    return false; // no digit fits → dead end
                }
            return true; // all cells filled
        }
    private boolean isValid(char[][] board, int row, int col, char c) {
        for (int i = 0; i < 9; i++) {
            if (board[row][i] == c) return false; // row
            if (board[i][col] == c) return false; // column
            if (board[3*(row/3) + i/3][3*(col/3) + i%3] == c) return false; // ← VARIATION: 3x3 box
        }
        return true;
    }
}

```

Time $O(9^m)$ m =empty cells | **Space** $O(1)$

#47 Permutations II

Description: Return all unique permutations of an array that may contain duplicates. **Variation:** sort first; use a `used[]` array; skip a value if the previous equal value at the same tree level has not been used (prevents duplicate permutations).

Variables: `nums` = sorted input (may have dups) · `used[i]` = whether `nums[i]` is in current path · `path` = permutation being built · `result` = all unique permutations **Pseudocode:**

```

sort nums
backtrack(used, path):
    if path full: add copy, return
    for i in 0..n-1:
        if used[i]: skip
        if i>0 and nums[i]==nums[i-1] and prev not used: skip dup at this level
        mark used, append nums[i]
        recurse
        unmark, remove last

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> permuteUnique(int[] nums) {
        Arrays.sort(nums); // ← VARIATION: sort to group duplicates
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(nums, new boolean[nums.length], new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int[] nums, boolean[] used, List<Integer> path, List<List<Integer>> result)
        if (path.size() == nums.length) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(path)); return; }
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            if (used[i]) continue;
            if (i > 0 && nums[i] == nums[i-1] && !used[i-1]) continue; // ← VARIATION: skip duplicate
            used[i] = true; path.add(nums[i]);
            backtrack(nums, used, path, result);
            used[i] = false; path.remove(path.size() - 1);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(n \cdot n!)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#51 N-Queens

Description: Place n queens on an $n \times n$ board so no two attack each other; return all distinct solutions. **Variation:** backtrack row by row; track occupied columns and both diagonals. Cells on the same $\backslash$ diagonal share $r - c$; cells on the same $/$ diagonal share $r + c$. ****Variables:**** n = board size · row = current row · c = candidate column · $queens[row]$ = chosen column for that row · $cols$ = occupied columns · $diag1$ = occupied $\backslash$ diagonals ($row - c$) · $diag2$ = occupied $/$ diagonals ($row + c$) · $result$ = all boards **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(row):
    if row == n: build board from queens, add, return
    for c in 0..n-1:
        if c in cols or row-c in diag1 or row+c in diag2: skip
        place queen: queens[row]=c, add to cols/diag1/diag2
        recurse(row+1)
        remove queen from cols/diag1/diag2

build(queens): make each row '.'*n with 'Q' at queens[r]

```



```

class Solution {
    public List<List<String>> solveNQueens(int n) {
        List<List<String>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        Set<Integer> cols = new HashSet<>(), diag1 = new HashSet<>(), diag2 = new HashSet<>();
        backtrack(0, n, new int[n], cols, diag1, diag2, result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int row, int n, int[] queens, Set<Integer> cols,
                           Set<Integer> diag1, Set<Integer> diag2, List<List<String>> result) {
        if (row == n) { result.add(build(queens, n)); return; }
        for (int c = 0; c < n; c++) {
            if (cols.contains(c) || diag1.contains(row - c) || diag2.contains(row + c)) continue; // ←
            queens[row] = c;
            cols.add(c); diag1.add(row - c); diag2.add(row + c);
            backtrack(row + 1, n, queens, cols, diag1, diag2, result);
            cols.remove(c); diag1.remove(row - c); diag2.remove(row + c);
        }
    }
    private List<String> build(int[] queens, int n) {
        List<String> board = new ArrayList<>();
        for (int r = 0; r < n; r++) {
            char[] row = new char[n];
            Arrays.fill(row, '.');
            row[queens[r]] = 'Q';
            board.add(new String(row));
        }
        return board;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n!)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#60 Permutation Sequence

Description: Return the kth permutation (1-indexed) of the sequence 1..n. **Variation:** no backtracking — use the factorial number system. Each position's digit is determined directly by $(k-1) / (\text{remaining}-1)!$. **Variables:** n = sequence size · k = target permutation (made 0-indexed) · digits = remaining available digits 1..n · $\text{factorial}[i] = i!$ · index = position of next digit to pick · result = answer string **Pseudocode:**

```

build factorial[] and digits list 1..n
k-- // 0-indexed
for i from n down to 1:
    index = k / factorial[i-1]
    k = k % factorial[i-1]
    append and remove digits[index]
return result

```

```

class Solution {
    public String getPermutation(int n, int k) {
        List<Integer> digits = new ArrayList<>();
        int[] factorial = new int[n + 1];
        factorial[0] = 1;
        for (int i = 1; i <= n; i++) { factorial[i] = factorial[i-1] * i; digits.add(i); }
        k--; // ← VARIATION: convert to 0-indexed
        StringBuilder result = new StringBuilder();
        for (int i = n; i >= 1; i--) {
            int index = k / factorial[i-1]; // ← VARIATION: direct digit selection
            k %= factorial[i-1];
            result.append(digits.remove(index));
        }
        return result.toString();
    }
}

```

Time $O(n^2)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#90 Subsets II

Description: Return all possible unique subsets of an array that may contain duplicates. **Variation:** sort first; within a recursion level, skip a value equal to its predecessor to avoid duplicate subsets. **Variables:** `nums` = sorted input (may have dups) · `start` = first index allowed · `path` = subset being built · `result` = all unique subsets **Pseudocode:**

```

sort nums
backtrack(start, path):
    record copy of path
    for i from start to end:
        if i > start and nums[i] == nums[i-1]: skip dup at same depth
        append nums[i]
        recurse with start = i+1
        remove last

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> subsetsWithDup(int[] nums) {
        Arrays.sort(nums); // ← VARIATION: sort to group duplicates
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(nums, 0, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int[] nums, int start, List<Integer> path, List<List<Integer>> result) {
        result.add(new ArrayList<>(path));
        for (int i = start; i < nums.length; i++) {
            if (i > start && nums[i] == nums[i-1]) continue; // ← VARIATION: skip duplicate at same de
            path.add(nums[i]);
            backtrack(nums, i + 1, path, result);
            path.remove(path.size() - 1);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(n \cdot 2^n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#216 Combination Sum III

Description: Find all combinations of k numbers from 1-9 (each used at most once) that sum to n . **Variation:** standard combination backtracking with start index $i+1$ (no reuse), but with two stopping constraints — count and remaining sum. **Variables:** k = required count of numbers · $remain$ = n minus sum so far · $start$ = smallest number allowed next · $path$ = combo being built · $result$ = all combos **Pseudocode:**

```
backtrack(remain, start, path):
    if path size == k and remain == 0: add copy, return
    if path size == k or remain < 0: return
    for i from start to 9:
        append i
        recurse with remain-i, start = i+1 (no reuse)
        remove last
```

```
class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> combinationSum3(int k, int n) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(k, n, 1, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int k, int remain, int start, List<Integer> path, List<List<Integer>> result)
        if (path.size() == k && remain == 0) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(path)); return; } // ← VARIA
        if (path.size() == k || remain < 0) return;
        for (int i = start; i <= 9; i++) {
            path.add(i);
            backtrack(k, remain - i, i + 1, path, result); // i+1: no reuse
            path.remove(path.size() - 1);
        }
    }
}
```

Time $O(C(9,k))$ | **Space** $O(k)$

#549 Binary Tree Longest Consecutive Sequence II

Description: Find the length of the longest consecutive path in a binary tree. The path can be increasing or decreasing and may go through a node (child-parent-child). **Variation:** post-order DFS returns a pair {increasing, decreasing} for each node. A path through the node combines an increasing run from one child with a decreasing run from the other.

Variables: $root$ = tree root · $node$ = current node · max = global longest consecutive path (node count) · inc / dec = longest increasing/decreasing run ending at node · $left, right$ = child {inc,dec} pairs **Pseudocode:**

```
dfs(root); return max

dfs(node):
    if node null: return {0,0}
    inc=1, dec=1
    left=dfs(left); right=dfs(right)
    if left child val+1==node.val: inc = left.inc+1
    elif left child val-1==node.val: dec = left.dec+1
    if right child val+1==node.val: inc = max(inc, right.inc+1)
    elif right child val-1==node.val: dec = max(dec, right.dec+1)
    max = max(max, inc+dec-1) // through node
    return {inc, dec}
```

```

class Solution {
    private int max = 0;
    public int longestConsecutive(TreeNode root) {
        dfs(root);
        return max;
    }
    private int[] dfs(TreeNode node) { // returns {inc, dec}
        if (node == null) return new int[]{0, 0};
        int inc = 1, dec = 1;
        int[] left = dfs(node.left), right = dfs(node.right);
        if (node.left != null) {
            if (node.left.val + 1 == node.val) inc = left[0] + 1; // ← VARIATION: increasing run
            else if (node.left.val - 1 == node.val) dec = left[1] + 1; // ← VARIATION: decreasing run
        }
        if (node.right != null) {
            if (node.right.val + 1 == node.val) inc = Math.max(inc, right[0] + 1);
            else if (node.right.val - 1 == node.val) dec = Math.max(dec, right[1] + 1);
        }
        max = Math.max(max, inc + dec - 1); // ← VARIATION: combine both directions th
        return new int[]{inc, dec};
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(h)

Additional Reference Problems

#17 Letter Combinations of a Phone Number

Description: Given a string of digits 2-9, return all letter combinations the phone keypad could represent. **Intuition:** backtrack one digit at a time, appending each candidate letter and undoing it.

Variables: MAP[d] = letters for digit d · start = current digit index · builder = current letter prefix · letters = candidate letters for digit at start **Pseudocode:**

```

if digits empty: return []
backtrack(start=0, empty builder)
return result

backtrack(start, builder):
    if start == length: record builder; return
    letters = MAP[digit at start]
    for each ch in letters:
        append ch
        backtrack(start+1, builder)
        remove last char

```

```

class Solution {
    private static final String[] MAP = {"", "", "abc", "def", "ghi", "jkl", "mno", "pqrs", "tuv", "wxy"};
    public List<String> letterCombinations(String digits) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (digits.isEmpty()) return result;
        backtrack(digits, 0, new StringBuilder(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(String digits, int start, StringBuilder builder, List<String> result) {
        if (start == digits.length()) { result.add(builder.toString()); return; }
        String letters = MAP[digits.charAt(start) - '0'];
        for (int i = 0; i < letters.length(); i++) {
            builder.append(letters.charAt(i));
            backtrack(digits, start + 1, builder, result);
            builder.deleteCharAt(builder.length() - 1);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(4^n \cdot n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#22 Generate Parentheses

Description: Generate all combinations of n pairs of well-formed parentheses. **Intuition:** add (while opens remain; add) only while closes outstanding; backtrack each choice.

Variables: open = remaining (to place · close = remaining) to place · builder = current parenthesis string

Pseudocode:

```

backtrack(open=n, close=n, empty builder)
return result

backtrack(open, close, builder):
    if open == 0 and close == 0: record builder; return
    if open > 0:
        append '('; backtrack(open-1, close); remove last
    if close > open:
        append ')'; backtrack(open, close-1); remove last

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> generateParenthesis(int n) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(n, n, new StringBuilder(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int open, int close, StringBuilder builder, List<String> result) {
        if (open == 0 && close == 0) { result.add(builder.toString()); return; }
        if (open > 0) {
            builder.append('(');
            backtrack(open - 1, close, builder, result);
            builder.deleteCharAt(builder.length() - 1);
        }
        if (close > open) {
            builder.append(')');
            backtrack(open, close - 1, builder, result);
            builder.deleteCharAt(builder.length() - 1);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(4^n/\sqrt{n})$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#36 Valid Sudoku

Description: Determine if a filled-in 9x9 Sudoku board is valid (no repeats in any row, column, or 3x3 box). **Intuition:** encode each digit's row/column/box membership into a HashSet of unique keys; a collision means invalid.

Variables: board = 9x9 grid · seen = set of membership keys · c = current digit · row / col / box = unique keys encoding c's row, column, and 3x3 box **Pseudocode:**

```

seen = empty set
for each cell (i,j):
    c = board[i][j]; if '.' skip
    build keys: c+"r"+i, c+"c"+j, c+"b"+(i/3)+(j/3)
    if any key already in seen: return false
return true

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean isValidSudoku(char[][] board) {
        Set<String> seen = new HashSet<>();
        for (int i = 0; i < 9; i++) {
            for (int j = 0; j < 9; j++) {
                char c = board[i][j];
                if (c == '.') { continue; }
                String row = c + "r" + i;
                String col = c + "c" + j;
                String box = c + "b" + (i / 3) + (j / 3);
                if (!seen.add(row) || !seen.add(col) || !seen.add(box)) {
                    return false;
                }
            }
        }
        return true;
    }
}

```

Time $O(1)$ (fixed 81 cells) | **Space** $O(1)$

#77 Combinations

Description: Return all combinations of k numbers chosen from 1 to n. **Intuition:** standard backtracking with start index advancing to i+1; record when path reaches size k.

Variables: n = range upper bound · k = target size · start = next candidate number · path = current combination

Pseudocode:

```
backtrack(start=1, empty path)
return result

backtrack(start, path):
    if path.size == k: record copy of path; return
    for i = start..n:
        add i to path
        backtrack(i+1, path)
        remove last from path
```

```
class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> combine(int n, int k) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(n, k, 1, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int n, int k, int start, List<Integer> path, List<List<Integer>> result) {
        if (path.size() == k) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(path)); return; }
        for (int i = start; i <= n; i++) {
            path.add(i);
            backtrack(n, k, i + 1, path, result);
            path.remove(path.size() - 1);
        }
    }
}
```

Time $O(k \cdot C(n, k))$ | **Space** $O(k)$

#93 Restore IP Addresses

Description: Return all valid IP addresses formable by inserting dots into a digit string. **Intuition:** backtrack choosing 1-3 digit segments; each segment must be 0-255 and have no leading zero.

Variables: start = index into s · parts = segments placed so far · builder = IP being built (with trailing dots) · len = current segment length · segment = candidate s[start, start+len) · mark = builder length before append

Pseudocode:

```

backtrack(start=0, parts=0, empty builder)
return result

backtrack(start, parts, builder):
    if parts == 4:
        if start == length: record builder without trailing dot
        return
    for len = 1..3 while start+len <= length:
        segment = s[start, start+len)
        if leading zero: break
        if value > 255: break
        mark = builder length
        append segment + '.'
        backtrack(start+len, parts+1, builder)
        truncate builder to mark

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> restoreIpAddresses(String s) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(s, 0, 0, new StringBuilder(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(String s, int start, int parts, StringBuilder builder, List<String> result)
        if (parts == 4) {
            if (start == s.length()) { result.add(builder.substring(0, builder.length() - 1)); }
            return;
        }
        for (int len = 1; len <= 3 && start + len <= s.length(); len++) {
            String segment = s.substring(start, start + len);
            if (segment.length() > 1 && segment.charAt(0) == '0') { break; }
            if (Integer.parseInt(segment) > 255) { break; }
            int mark = builder.length();
            builder.append(segment).append('.');
            backtrack(s, start + len, parts + 1, builder, result);
            builder.setLength(mark);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(1)$ (bounded branching) | **Space** $O(1)$

#94 Binary Tree Inorder Traversal

Description: Return the inorder traversal (left → root → right) of a binary tree. **Intuition:** recurse left, visit node, recurse right.

Variables: `node` = current subtree root · `result` = inorder values **Pseudocode:**

```

dfs(root); return result

dfs(node):
    if node null: return
    dfs(node.left)
    add node.val
    dfs(node.right)

```



```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> inorderTraversal(TreeNode root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        dfs(root, result);
        return result;
    }
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, List<Integer> result) {
        if (node == null) return;
        dfs(node.left, result);
        result.add(node.val);
        dfs(node.right, result);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#95 Unique Binary Search Trees II

Description: Generate all structurally unique BSTs storing values $1..n$. **Intuition:** pick each value as root; recursively build all left subtrees from the smaller range and all right subtrees from the larger range, then combine.

Variables: $[lo, hi]$ = inclusive value range for subtree · i = chosen root value · $left$ = all left subtrees from $[lo, i-1]$ · $right$ = all right subtrees from $[i+1, hi]$ **Pseudocode:**

```

if n == 0: return []
return build(1, n)

build(lo, hi):
    if lo > hi: return [null]
    for i = lo..hi:
        left = build(lo, i-1)
        right = build(i+1, hi)
        for each l in left, each r in right:
            make root i with children l, r; add to result
    return result

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<TreeNode> generateTrees(int n) {
        if (n == 0) return new ArrayList<>();
        return build(1, n);
    }
    private List<TreeNode> build(int lo, int hi) {
        List<TreeNode> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (lo > hi) { result.add(null); return result; }
        for (int i = lo; i <= hi; i++) {
            List<TreeNode> left = build(lo, i - 1);
            List<TreeNode> right = build(i + 1, hi);
            for (TreeNode l : left) {
                for (TreeNode r : right) {
                    TreeNode root = new TreeNode(i);
                    root.left = l;
                    root.right = r;
                    result.add(root);
                }
            }
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n \cdot \text{Catalan}(n))$ | **Space** $O(n \cdot \text{Catalan}(n))$

#99 Recover Binary Search Tree

Description: Two nodes of a BST were swapped by mistake; recover the tree without changing its structure. **Intuition:** an inorder traversal of a valid BST is ascending; the swapped pair shows up as one or two descents. Track them and swap their values.

Variables: `first`, `second` = the two swapped nodes · `prev` = previous node in inorder order · `node` = current node

Pseudocode:

```

inorder(root)
swap first.val and second.val

inorder(node):
    if node null: return
    inorder(node.left)
    if prev exists and prev.val > node.val:
        if first not set: first = prev
        second = node
    prev = node
    inorder(node.right)

```

```

class Solution {
    private TreeNode first = null, second = null, prev = null;
    public void recoverTree(TreeNode root) {
        inorder(root);
        int temp = first.val;
        first.val = second.val;
        second.val = temp;
    }
    private void inorder(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return;
        inorder(node.left);
        if (prev != null && prev.val > node.val) {
            if (first == null) { first = prev; }
            second = node;
        }
        prev = node;
        inorder(node.right);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#100 Same Tree

Description: Check if two binary trees are structurally identical with the same node values. **Intuition:** both null is equal; one null or differing values is not; otherwise recurse on both children.

Variables: `p`, `q` = corresponding nodes in the two trees **Pseudocode:**

```

isSameTree(p, q):
    if both null: return true
    if exactly one null: return false
    if p.val != q.val: return false
    return isSameTree(p.left, q.left) and isSameTree(p.right, q.right)

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean isSameTree(TreeNode p, TreeNode q) {
        if (p == null && q == null) return true;
        if (p == null || q == null) return false;
        if (p.val != q.val) return false;
        return isSameTree(p.left, q.left) && isSameTree(p.right, q.right);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#101 Symmetric Tree

Description: Check if a binary tree is a mirror image of itself. **Intuition:** compare the outer pairs and inner pairs of two mirrored subtrees.

Variables: `a`, `b` = mirrored node pair being compared **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return true
return mirror(root.left, root.right)

mirror(a, b):
    if both null: return true
    if exactly one null: return false
    if a.val != b.val: return false
    return mirror(a.left, b.right) and mirror(a.right, b.left)

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean isSymmetric(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return true;
        return mirror(root.left, root.right);
    }
    private boolean mirror(TreeNode a, TreeNode b) {
        if (a == null && b == null) return true;
        if (a == null || b == null) return false;
        if (a.val != b.val) return false;
        return mirror(a.left, b.right) && mirror(a.right, b.left);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#102 Binary Tree Level Order Traversal

Description: Return node values level by level, left to right. **Intuition:** BFS with a queue; drain one level's worth of nodes per outer iteration.

Variables: `queue` = nodes pending by level · `size` = node count of current level · `level` = current level's values · `node` = dequeued node **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return []
enqueue root
while queue not empty:
    size = queue size
    level = []
    repeat size times:
        node = dequeue
        add node.val to level
        enqueue non-null children
    add level to result
return result

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> levelOrder(TreeNode root) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            List<Integer> level = new ArrayList<>();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                level.add(node.val);
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            }
            result.add(level);
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#103 Binary Tree Zigzag Level Order Traversal

Description: Return node values level by level, alternating left-to-right and right-to-left. **Intuition:** standard BFS, but reverse the level list on alternate levels.

Variables: `queue` = nodes pending by level · `leftToRight` = current level direction · `size` = current level node count · `level` = deque of current level values · `node` = dequeued node **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return []
enqueue root; leftToRight = true
while queue not empty:
    size = queue size
    level = empty deque
    repeat size times:
        node = dequeue
        if leftToRight: add node.val at end else at front
        enqueue non-null children
    add level to result
    flip leftToRight
return result

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> zigzagLevelOrder(TreeNode root) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        boolean leftToRight = true;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            LinkedList<Integer> level = new LinkedList<>();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                if (leftToRight) { level.addLast(node.val); }
                else { level.addFirst(node.val); }
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            }
            result.add(level);
            leftToRight = !leftToRight;
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#105 Construct Binary Tree from Preorder and Inorder Traversal

Description: Reconstruct a binary tree from its preorder and inorder traversals. **Intuition:** the first preorder element is the root; its position in inorder splits left/right subtree sizes.

Variables: `preIndex` = next preorder position · `inIndex` = value → inorder index map · `[lo, hi]` = inorder range of current subtree · `rootVal` = root value · `mid` = root's inorder index **Pseudocode:**

```

map each inorder value to its index
return build(0, n-1)

```

```

build(lo, hi):
    if lo > hi: return null
    rootVal = preorder[preIndex++]
    root = node(rootVal)
    mid = inIndex[rootVal]
    root.left = build(lo, mid-1)
    root.right = build(mid+1, hi)
    return root

```

```

class Solution {
    private int preIndex = 0;
    private Map<Integer, Integer> inIndex = new HashMap<>();
    private int[] preorder;
    public TreeNode buildTree(int[] preorder, int[] inorder) {
        this.preorder = preorder;
        for (int i = 0; i < inorder.length; i++) { inIndex.put(inorder[i], i); }
        return build(0, inorder.length - 1);
    }
    private TreeNode build(int lo, int hi) {
        if (lo > hi) return null;
        int rootVal = preorder[preIndex++];
        TreeNode root = new TreeNode(rootVal);
        int mid = inIndex.get(rootVal);
        root.left = build(lo, mid - 1);
        root.right = build(mid + 1, hi);
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#106 Construct Binary Tree from Inorder and Postorder Traversal

Description: Reconstruct a binary tree from its inorder and postorder traversals. **Intuition:** the last postorder element is the root; build right subtree before left since postorder is consumed back to front.

Variables: `postIndex` = next postorder position (back to front) · `inIndex` = value → inorder index map · `[lo, hi]` = inorder range of current subtree · `rootVal` = root value · `mid` = root's inorder index **Pseudocode:**

```

postIndex = n-1
map each inorder value to its index
return build(0, n-1)

build(lo, hi):
    if lo > hi: return null
    rootVal = postorder[postIndex--]
    root = node(rootVal)
    mid = inIndex[rootVal]
    root.right = build(mid+1, hi)
    root.left = build(lo, mid-1)
    return root

```

```

class Solution {
    private int postIndex;
    private Map<Integer, Integer> inIndex = new HashMap<>();
    private int[] postorder;
    public TreeNode buildTree(int[] inorder, int[] postorder) {
        this.postorder = postorder;
        this.postIndex = postorder.length - 1;
        for (int i = 0; i < inorder.length; i++) { inIndex.put(inorder[i], i); }
        return build(0, inorder.length - 1);
    }
    private TreeNode build(int lo, int hi) {
        if (lo > hi) return null;
        int rootVal = postorder[postIndex--];
        TreeNode root = new TreeNode(rootVal);
        int mid = inIndex.get(rootVal);
        root.right = build(mid + 1, hi);
        root.left = build(lo, mid - 1);
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#107 Binary Tree Level Order Traversal II

Description: Return node values level by level, from bottom to top. **Intuition:** standard BFS, then reverse the list of levels.

Variables: queue = nodes pending by level · size = current level node count · level = current level values · node = dequeued node **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return []
enqueue root
while queue not empty:
    size = queue size
    level = []
    repeat size times:
        node = dequeue
        add node.val to level
        enqueue non-null children
    add level to result
reverse result
return result

```



```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> levelOrderBottom(TreeNode root) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            List<Integer> level = new ArrayList<>();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                level.add(node.val);
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            }
            result.add(level);
        }
        Collections.reverse(result);
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#108 Convert Sorted Array to Binary Search Tree

Description: Convert a sorted array to a height-balanced BST. **Intuition:** pick the middle element as the root so left and right halves are balanced; recurse on each half.

Variables: `[lo, hi]` = inclusive array range for subtree · `mid` = midpoint chosen as root **Pseudocode:**

```

return build(0, n-1)

build(lo, hi):
    if lo > hi: return null
    mid = lo + (hi-lo)/2
    root = node(nums[mid])
    root.left = build(lo, mid-1)
    root.right = build(mid+1, hi)
    return root

```

```

class Solution {
    public TreeNode sortedArrayToBST(int[] nums) {
        return build(nums, 0, nums.length - 1);
    }
    private TreeNode build(int[] nums, int lo, int hi) {
        if (lo > hi) return null;
        int mid = lo + (hi - lo) / 2;
        TreeNode root = new TreeNode(nums[mid]);
        root.left = build(nums, lo, mid - 1);
        root.right = build(nums, mid + 1, hi);
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(\log n)$

#111 Minimum Depth of Binary Tree

Description: Find the shortest path length from root to any leaf. **Intuition:** like max depth, but a node with one missing child must take the existing child's depth (a non-leaf cannot end a root-to-leaf path).

Variables: `left` = min depth of left subtree · `right` = min depth of right subtree **Pseudocode:**

```
minDepth(root):
    if root null: return 0
    left = minDepth(root.left)
    right = minDepth(root.right)
    if one child missing: return max(left, right) + 1
    return min(left, right) + 1
```

```
class Solution {
    public int minDepth(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return 0;
        int left = minDepth(root.left);
        int right = minDepth(root.right);
        if (root.left == null || root.right == null) {
            return Math.max(left, right) + 1; // ← VARIATION: skip the null side
        }
        return Math.min(left, right) + 1;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#114 Flatten Binary Tree to Linked List

Description: Flatten a binary tree into a right-pointer linked list following preorder, in place. **Intuition:** reverse-preorder traversal (right, left, node) lets you prepend each node to a running tail.

Variables: `prev` = head of already-flattened suffix (built in reverse preorder) · `root` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```
flatten(root):
    if root null: return
    flatten(root.right)
    flatten(root.left)
    root.right = prev
    root.left = null
    prev = root
```

```
class Solution {
    private TreeNode prev = null;
    public void flatten(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return;
        flatten(root.right);
        flatten(root.left);
        root.right = prev;
        root.left = null;
        prev = root;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#116 Populating Next Right Pointers in Each Node

Description: Connect each node's `next` pointer to its right neighbor in a perfect binary tree, using $O(1)$ extra space.

Intuition: use already-established `next` links of the current level to thread the next level.

Variables: `leftmost` = leftmost node of current level · `head` = node walking across current level **Pseudocode:**

```
leftmost = root
while leftmost and leftmost.left exist:
    head = leftmost
    while head not null:
        head.left.next = head.right
        if head.next exists: head.right.next = head.next.left
        head = head.next
    leftmost = leftmost.left
return root
```

```
class Solution {
    public Node connect(Node root) {
        Node leftmost = root;
        while (leftmost != null && leftmost.left != null) {
            Node head = leftmost;
            while (head != null) {
                head.left.next = head.right;
                if (head.next != null) { head.right.next = head.next.left; }
                head = head.next;
            }
            leftmost = leftmost.left;
        }
        return root;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(1)$

#117 Populating Next Right Pointers in Each Node II

Description: Same as #116 but for an arbitrary binary tree. **Intuition:** walk each level via `next` links, building the next level's chain through a dummy head since children may be missing.

Variables: `head` = leftmost node of current level · `dummy` = sentinel before next level's chain · `tail` = builder tail for next level · `cur` = node walking across current level **Pseudocode:**

```
head = root
while head not null:
    dummy = sentinel; tail = dummy
    for cur = head across level via next:
        if cur.left: tail.next = cur.left; advance tail
        if cur.right: tail.next = cur.right; advance tail
    head = dummy.next
return root
```

```

class Solution {
    public Node connect(Node root) {
        Node head = root;
        while (head != null) {
            Node dummy = new Node(0);
            Node tail = dummy;
            for (Node cur = head; cur != null; cur = cur.next) {
                if (cur.left != null) { tail.next = cur.left; tail = tail.next; }
                if (cur.right != null) { tail.next = cur.right; tail = tail.next; }
            }
            head = dummy.next;
        }
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(1)$

#144 Binary Tree Preorder Traversal

Description: Return the preorder traversal (root $\rightarrow$ left $\rightarrow$ right) of a binary tree. **Intuition:** visit node, recurse left, recurse right.

Variables: `node` = current subtree root · `result` = preorder values **Pseudocode:**

```
dfs(root); return result
```

```

dfs(node):
    if node null: return
    add node.val
    dfs(node.left)
    dfs(node.right)

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> preorderTraversal(TreeNode root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        dfs(root, result);
        return result;
    }
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, List<Integer> result) {
        if (node == null) return;
        result.add(node.val);
        dfs(node.left, result);
        dfs(node.right, result);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#145 Binary Tree Postorder Traversal

Description: Return the postorder traversal (left $\rightarrow$ right $\rightarrow$ root) of a binary tree. **Intuition:** recurse left, recurse right, visit node.

Variables: `node` = current subtree root · `result` = postorder values **Pseudocode:**

```
dfs(root); return result
```

```
dfs(node):  
    if node null: return  
    dfs(node.left)  
    dfs(node.right)  
    add node.val
```

```
class Solution {  
    public List<Integer> postorderTraversal(TreeNode root) {  
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();  
        dfs(root, result);  
        return result;  
    }  
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, List<Integer> result) {  
        if (node == null) return;  
        dfs(node.left, result);  
        dfs(node.right, result);  
        result.add(node.val);  
    }  
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#199 Binary Tree Right Side View

Description: Return the values visible from the right side, one per level. **Intuition:** BFS each level; the last node dequeued in a level is the rightmost visible one.

Variables: `queue` = nodes pending by level · `size` = current level node count · `node` = dequeued node · `i` = index within level **Pseudocode:**

```
if root null: return []  
enqueue root  
while queue not empty:  
    size = queue size  
    for i = 0..size-1:  
        node = dequeue  
        if i == size-1: add node.val (rightmost)  
        enqueue non-null children  
return result
```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> rightSideView(TreeNode root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                if (i == size - 1) { result.add(node.val); }
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            }
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#222 Count Complete Tree Nodes

Description: Count nodes in a complete binary tree faster than $O(n)$. **Intuition:** if leftmost and rightmost depths match, the subtree is perfect ($2^h - 1$ nodes); otherwise recurse on both children.

Variables: `left` = leftmost path depth · `right` = rightmost path depth · `d` = depth counter in helpers **Pseudocode:**

```

countNodes(root):
    if root null: return 0
    left = leftDepth(root)
    right = rightDepth(root)
    if left == right: return 2^left - 1    // perfect subtree
    return 1 + countNodes(root.left) + countNodes(root.right)

```

```

leftDepth/rightDepth(node):
    d = 0; walk down left/right counting nodes; return d

```

```

class Solution {
    public int countNodes(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return 0;
        int left = leftDepth(root);
        int right = rightDepth(root);
        if (left == right) { return (1 << left) - 1; }    // ← VARIATION: perfect subtree shortcut
        return 1 + countNodes(root.left) + countNodes(root.right);
    }
    private int leftDepth(TreeNode node) {
        int d = 0;
        while (node != null) { d++; node = node.left; }
        return d;
    }
    private int rightDepth(TreeNode node) {
        int d = 0;
        while (node != null) { d++; node = node.right; }
        return d;
    }
}

```

Time $O(\log^2 n)$ | **Space** $O(\log n)$

#235 Lowest Common Ancestor of a Binary Search Tree

Description: Find the LCA of two nodes in a BST. **Intuition:** if both values are less than the node, go left; if both greater, go right; otherwise the node is the split point = LCA.

Variables: `root` = current node walking down · `p`, `q` = target nodes **Pseudocode:**

```
while root not null:
    if both p,q < root.val: root = root.left
    else if both p,q > root.val: root = root.right
    else: return root    // split point
return null
```

```
class Solution {
    public TreeNode lowestCommonAncestor(TreeNode root, TreeNode p, TreeNode q) {
        while (root != null) {
            if (p.val < root.val && q.val < root.val) { root = root.left; }
            else if (p.val > root.val && q.val > root.val) { root = root.right; }
            else { return root; }
        }
        return null;
    }
}
```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(1)$

#236 Lowest Common Ancestor of a Binary Tree

Description: Find the LCA of two nodes in a general binary tree. **Intuition:** post-order: if p or q matches the node, return it; the node where both arms return non-null is the LCA.

Variables: `root` = current node · `p`, `q` = target nodes · `left` = LCA result from left subtree · `right` = LCA result from right subtree **Pseudocode:**

```
lowestCommonAncestor(root, p, q):
    if root null or root is p or q: return root
    left = recurse on root.left
    right = recurse on root.right
    if left and right both non-null: return root
    return whichever of left/right is non-null
```

```
class Solution {
    public TreeNode lowestCommonAncestor(TreeNode root, TreeNode p, TreeNode q) {
        if (root == null || root == p || root == q) return root;
        TreeNode left = lowestCommonAncestor(root.left, p, q);
        TreeNode right = lowestCommonAncestor(root.right, p, q);
        if (left != null && right != null) return root;
        return left != null ? left : right;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#241 Different Ways to Add Parentheses

Description: Compute all results obtainable by parenthesizing an expression differently. **Intuition:** at each operator, split into left and right subexpressions, recursively evaluate both, and combine every pair.

Variables: `i` = scan index · `c` = current char · `left` = results of left subexpression · `right` = results of right subexpression · `a`, `b` = one operand pair **Pseudocode:**

```
diffWaysToCompute(expression):
    for i over expression:
        c = char at i
        if c is operator:
            left = diffWaysToCompute(expression[0, i))
            right = diffWaysToCompute(expression[i+1, end])
            for each a in left, each b in right:
                apply c to a,b; add to result
        if result empty: result = [parse expression as int]
    return result
```

```
class Solution {
    public List<Integer> diffWaysToCompute(String expression) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        for (int i = 0; i < expression.length(); i++) {
            char c = expression.charAt(i);
            if (c == '+' || c == '-' || c == '*') {
                List<Integer> left = diffWaysToCompute(expression.substring(0, i));
                List<Integer> right = diffWaysToCompute(expression.substring(i + 1));
                for (int a : left) {
                    for (int b : right) {
                        if (c == '+') { result.add(a + b); }
                        else if (c == '-') { result.add(a - b); }
                        else { result.add(a * b); }
                    }
                }
            }
        }
        if (result.isEmpty()) { result.add(Integer.parseInt(expression)); }
        return result;
    }
}
```

Time $O(\text{Catalan}(n))$ | **Space** $O(\text{Catalan}(n))$

#250 Count Univalue Subtrees

Description: Count subtrees in which all nodes share the same value. **Intuition:** post-order; a subtree is univalue if both children are univalue and their values match the node's value.

Variables: `count` = running total of univalue subtrees · `left / right` = whether each child subtree is univalue

Pseudocode:


```

isUnival(root); return count
isUnival(node):
    if node null: return true
    left = isUnival(node.left); right = isUnival(node.right)
    if either child not unival: return false
    if left child exists and differs in value: return false
    if right child exists and differs in value: return false
    count++; return true

```

```

class Solution {
    private int count = 0;
    public int countUnivalSubtrees(TreeNode root) {
        isUnival(root);
        return count;
    }
    private boolean isUnival(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return true;
        boolean left = isUnival(node.left);
        boolean right = isUnival(node.right);
        if (!left || !right) return false;
        if (node.left != null && node.left.val != node.val) return false;
        if (node.right != null && node.right.val != node.val) return false;
        count++;
        return true;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#255 Verify Preorder Sequence in Binary Search Tree

Description: Verify whether an array is a valid BST preorder traversal. **Intuition:** use a stack to simulate the path; popping when a value exceeds the top sets a lower bound. Any later value below that bound is invalid.

Variables: `stack` = path of ancestors with no right child yet seen · `lowerBound` = min allowed value once we turn right

Pseudocode:

```

lowerBound = -inf
for each value in preorder:
    if value < lowerBound: return false
    while stack nonempty and top < value: lowerBound = pop()
    push(value)
return true

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean verifyPreorder(int[] preorder) {
        Deque<Integer> stack = new ArrayDeque<>();
        int lowerBound = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
        for (int value : preorder) {
            if (value < lowerBound) return false;
            while (!stack.isEmpty() && stack.peek() < value) {
                lowerBound = stack.pop();
            }
            stack.push(value);
        }
        return true;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#267 Palindrome Permutation II

Description: Return all palindrome permutations of a string. **Intuition:** a palindrome needs at most one odd-count character; build half the palindrome by permuting half the characters, then mirror it.

Variables: `count[c]` = frequency of char `c` · `mid` = single odd-count char (center) · `half` = chars for one half · `used[i]` = whether `half[i]` is placed · `builder` = current half being built **Pseudocode:**

```

count frequencies of all chars
for each char i:
    if odd count: if mid already set return [] else mid = char i
    add count[i]/2 copies of char i to half
backtrack(half, used, builder, mid)
backtrack:
    if builder full: result += builder + mid + reverse(builder); return
    for each i in half:
        if used or (duplicate of prev unused): skip
        mark used, append half[i]
        recurse
        undo append, unmark

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> generatePalindromes(String s) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        int[] count = new int[128];
        for (char c : s.toCharArray()) { count[c]++; }
        String mid = "";
        List<Character> half = new ArrayList<>();
        for (int i = 0; i < 128; i++) {
            if (count[i] % 2 == 1) {
                if (!mid.isEmpty()) return result; // more than one odd → impossible
                mid = String.valueOf((char) i);
            }
            for (int j = 0; j < count[i] / 2; j++) { half.add((char) i); }
        }
        backtrack(half, new boolean[half.size()], new StringBuilder(), mid, result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(List<Character> half, boolean[] used, StringBuilder builder, String mid, List<String> result) {
        if (builder.length() == half.size()) {
            String left = builder.toString();
            result.add(left + mid + new StringBuilder(left).reverse());
            return;
        }
        for (int i = 0; i < half.size(); i++) {
            if (used[i]) continue;
            if (i > 0 && half.get(i).equals(half.get(i - 1)) && !used[i - 1]) continue;
            used[i] = true;
            builder.append(half.get(i));
            backtrack(half, used, builder, mid, result);
            builder.deleteCharAt(builder.length() - 1);
            used[i] = false;
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O((n/2)!)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#272 Closest Binary Search Tree Value II

Description: Find the k values in a BST closest to a target. **Intuition:** inorder gives sorted values; keep a sliding window of size k, evicting the farther end while a closer candidate exists.

Variables: `window` = deque of k closest values so far (sorted) · `target` = value to be close to · `k` = window size

Pseudocode:

```

inorder(root); return window as list
inorder(node):
    if null: return
    recurse left
    if window smaller than k: add node.val at back
    else if node.val closer than front element: remove front, add node.val at back
    else: return // farther from here on, stop early
    recurse right

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> closestKValues(TreeNode root, double target, int k) {
        Deque<Integer> window = new ArrayDeque<>();
        inorder(root, target, k, window);
        return new ArrayList<>(window);
    }
    private void inorder(TreeNode node, double target, int k, Deque<Integer> window) {
        if (node == null) return;
        inorder(node.left, target, k, window);
        if (window.size() < k) {
            window.offerLast(node.val);
        } else if (Math.abs(node.val - target) < Math.abs(window.peekFirst() - target)) {
            window.pollFirst();
            window.offerLast(node.val);
        } else {
            return; // ← VARIATION: values only get farther, stop early
        }
        inorder(node.right, target, k, window);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#282 Expression Add Operators

Description: Insert +, -, * between digits of a string to reach a target value; return all expressions. **Intuition:** backtrack each operand prefix; track running value and the last multiplied term so * can fold correctly.

Variables: `start` = index where current operand begins · `value` = running evaluated total · `prev` = last term (for * folding) · `cur` = current operand · `builder` = expression so far · `len` = builder length to truncate back to **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(start=0, value=0, prev=0)
if start at end: if value == target record builder; return
for i from start to end:
    if operand has leading zero: break
    cur = num[start..i]
    if start == 0:
        append cur; recurse(i+1, cur, cur); truncate
    else:
        append "+cur"; recurse(i+1, value+cur, cur); truncate
        append "-cur"; recurse(i+1, value-cur, -cur); truncate
        append "*cur"; recurse(i+1, value-prev+prev*cur, prev*cur); truncate

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> addOperators(String num, int target) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(num, target, 0, 0, 0, new StringBuilder(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(String num, int target, int start, long value, long prev, StringBuilder builder, List<String> result) {
        if (start == num.length()) {
            if (value == target) { result.add(builder.toString()); }
            return;
        }
        for (int i = start; i < num.length(); i++) {
            if (i > start && num.charAt(start) == '0') break; // no leading zero
            long cur = Long.parseLong(num.substring(start, i + 1));
            int len = builder.length();
            if (start == 0) {
                builder.append(cur);
                backtrack(num, target, i + 1, cur, cur, builder, result);
                builder.setLength(len);
            } else {
                builder.append('+').append(cur);
                backtrack(num, target, i + 1, value + cur, cur, builder, result);
                builder.setLength(len);

                builder.append('-').append(cur);
                backtrack(num, target, i + 1, value - cur, -cur, builder, result);
                builder.setLength(len);

                builder.append('*').append(cur);
                backtrack(num, target, i + 1, value - prev + prev * cur, prev * cur, builder, result);
                builder.setLength(len);
            }
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(4^n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#291 Word Pattern II

Description: Check if a string follows a pattern where each pattern char maps to a non-empty, non-overlapping substring. **Intuition:** backtrack assigning substrings to pattern characters, enforcing a bijection via two maps.

Variables: `pi` = index in pattern · `si` = index in string `s` · `map` = pattern char to assigned substring · `used` = set of substrings already assigned · `candidate` = trial substring `s[si..i]` **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(pi=0, si=0)
if both exhausted: return true
if one exhausted: return false
c = pattern[pi]
if c already mapped:
    if s does not start with mapped at si: return false
    return recurse(pi+1, si + mapped length)
for i from si to end:
    candidate = s[si..i]
    if candidate already used: skip
    map c -> candidate, mark used
    if recurse(pi+1, i+1): return true
    unmap, unmark
return false

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean wordPatternMatch(String pattern, String s) {
        return backtrack(pattern, 0, s, 0, new HashMap<>(), new HashSet<>());
    }
    private boolean backtrack(String pattern, int pi, String s, int si, Map<Character, String> map, Set
        if (pi == pattern.length() && si == s.length()) return true;
        if (pi == pattern.length() || si == s.length()) return false;
        char c = pattern.charAt(pi);
        if (map.containsKey(c)) {
            String mapped = map.get(c);
            if (!s.startsWith(mapped, si)) return false;
            return backtrack(pattern, pi + 1, s, si + mapped.length(), map, used);
        }
        for (int i = si; i < s.length(); i++) {
            String candidate = s.substring(si, i + 1);
            if (used.contains(candidate)) continue;
            map.put(c, candidate);
            used.add(candidate);
            if (backtrack(pattern, pi + 1, s, i + 1, map, used)) return true;
            map.remove(c);
            used.remove(candidate);
        }
        return false;
    }
}

```

Time O(exponential) | **Space** O(n)

#293 Flip Game

Description: Given a string of '+' and '-', return all states after flipping one "++" to "--". **Intuition:** scan for each "++" occurrence and produce the flipped string.

Variables: `arr` = mutable char array of state · `i` = position of candidate "++" **Pseudocode:**

```

for i in 0..len-2:
    if arr[i]=='+' and arr[i+1]=='':
        flip both to '-'
        record new string
        restore both to '+'
return result

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> generatePossibleNextMoves(String currentState) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        char[] arr = currentState.toCharArray();
        for (int i = 0; i + 1 < arr.length; i++) {
            if (arr[i] == '+' && arr[i + 1] == '+') {
                arr[i] = '-';
                arr[i + 1] = '-';
                result.add(new String(arr));
                arr[i] = '+';
                arr[i + 1] = '+';
            }
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n^2)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#294 Flip Game II

Description: Determine if the first player can guarantee a win in Flip Game. **Intuition:** the current player wins if any "++" flip leaves the opponent in a losing position; memoize states.

Variables: `state` = current board string · `memo` = state to win/lose result · `next` = board after flipping a "++" at `i`

Pseudocode:

```

canWin(state):
    if state in memo: return memo
    for i in 0..len-2:
        if "++" at i:
            next = flip both to "--"
            if not canWin(next): memo[state]=true; return true
    memo[state]=false; return false

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean canWin(String currentState) {
        return canWin(currentState, new HashMap<>());
    }
    private boolean canWin(String state, Map<String, Boolean> memo) {
        if (memo.containsKey(state)) return memo.get(state);
        for (int i = 0; i + 1 < state.length(); i++) {
            if (state.charAt(i) == '+' && state.charAt(i + 1) == '+') {
                String next = state.substring(0, i) + "---" + state.substring(i + 2);
                if (!canWin(next, memo)) {
                    memo.put(state, true);
                    return true;
                }
            }
        }
        memo.put(state, false);
        return false;
    }
}

```

Time $O(\text{exponential, memoized})$ | **Space** $O(\text{states})$

#297 Serialize and Deserialize Binary Tree

Description: Serialize a binary tree to a string and deserialize it back. **Intuition:** preorder with explicit "#" null markers uniquely encodes structure; rebuild by consuming tokens in the same order.

Variables: `builder` = output buffer · `queue` = tokens split by comma · `token` = current node value or "#" (null)

Pseudocode:

```

serialize(node, builder):
    if null: append "#,"; return
    append val + ","
    serialize left; serialize right
deserialize(data):
    queue = tokens of data
    return build(queue)
build(queue):
    token = poll
    if "#": return null
    node = new node(token)
    node.left = build; node.right = build
    return node

```



```

public class Codec {
    public String serialize(TreeNode root) {
        StringBuilder builder = new StringBuilder();
        serialize(root, builder);
        return builder.toString();
    }
    private void serialize(TreeNode node, StringBuilder builder) {
        if (node == null) { builder.append("#,"); return; }
        builder.append(node.val).append(',');
        serialize(node.left, builder);
        serialize(node.right, builder);
    }
    public TreeNode deserialize(String data) {
        Queue<String> queue = new ArrayDeque<>(Arrays.asList(data.split(",")));
        return deserialize(queue);
    }
    private TreeNode deserialize(Queue<String> queue) {
        String token = queue.poll();
        if (token.equals("#")) return null;
        TreeNode node = new TreeNode(Integer.parseInt(token));
        node.left = deserialize(queue);
        node.right = deserialize(queue);
        return node;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#298 Binary Tree Longest Consecutive Sequence

Description: Find the longest consecutive increasing-by-1 path going from parent to child. **Intuition:** pass the current run length down; extend it when the child is exactly parent + 1, otherwise reset to 1.

Variables: `max` = longest consecutive run found · `parent` = previous node on path · `length` = current consecutive run length **Pseudocode:**

```

dfs(root, null, 0); return max
dfs(node, parent, length):
    if null: return
    if parent exists and node.val == parent.val+1: length++
    else: length = 1
    max = max(max, length)
    dfs(left, node, length); dfs(right, node, length)

```

```

class Solution {
    private int max = 0;
    public int longestConsecutive(TreeNode root) {
        dfs(root, null, 0);
        return max;
    }
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, TreeNode parent, int length) {
        if (node == null) return;
        if (parent != null && node.val == parent.val + 1) { length++; }
        else { length = 1; }
        max = Math.max(max, length);
        dfs(node.left, node, length);
        dfs(node.right, node, length);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#301 Remove Invalid Parentheses

Description: Remove the minimum number of parentheses to make a string valid; return all distinct results. **Intuition:** BFS by removal count; the first level whose strings include valid ones is the minimum-removal answer.

Variables: `queue` = BFS frontier of candidate strings · `visited` = strings already enqueued · `found` = whether a valid string was found at current level · `cur` = current string · `balance` = paren balance in validity check **Pseudocode:**

```

enqueue s, mark visited
while queue nonempty:
    cur = poll
    if valid: add to result, found = true
    if found: skip expanding (only finish this level)
    for each position i:
        if char not a paren: skip
        next = cur without char i
        if newly visited: enqueue
return result
isValid: scan tracking balance, fail if it goes negative, require 0 at end

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> removeInvalidParentheses(String s) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        Set<String> visited = new HashSet<>();
        Queue<String> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(s);
        visited.add(s);
        boolean found = false;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            String cur = queue.poll();
            if (isValid(cur)) { result.add(cur); found = true; }
            if (found) continue;
            for (int i = 0; i < cur.length(); i++) {
                if (cur.charAt(i) != '(' && cur.charAt(i) != ')') continue;
                String next = cur.substring(0, i) + cur.substring(i + 1);
                if (visited.add(next)) { queue.offer(next); }
            }
        }
        return result;
    }
    private boolean isValid(String s) {
        int balance = 0;
        for (char c : s.toCharArray()) {
            if (c == '(') { balance++; }
            else if (c == ')') { balance--; if (balance < 0) return false; }
        }
        return balance == 0;
    }
}

```

Time $O(2^n)$ | **Space** $O(2^n)$

#306 Additive Number

Description: Check if a string forms an additive sequence (each number is the sum of the two preceding). **Intuition:** backtrack the first two numbers; the rest of the string is forced, so just verify it matches the running sums.

Variables: i = end of first number $[0, i)$ · j = end of second number $[i, j)$ · $first / second$ = first two numbers
 · sum = first+second · $sumStr$ = its string · $start$ = index in num to match next **Pseudocode:**

```

for i from 1 to n/2 (no leading-zero first):
    for j from i+1 while remaining long enough (no leading-zero second):
        first = num[0..i), second = num[i..j)
        if check(first, second, j): return true
return false
check(first, second, start):
    if start at end: return true
    sum = first+second; sumStr = its string
    if num does not start with sumStr at start: return false
    return check(second, sum, start + sumStr length)

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean isAdditiveNumber(String num) {
        int n = num.length();
        for (int i = 1; i <= n / 2; i++) {
            if (num.charAt(0) == '0' && i > 1) break;
            for (int j = i + 1; n - j >= Math.max(i, j - i); j++) {
                if (num.charAt(i) == '0' && j - i > 1) break;
                long first = Long.parseLong(num.substring(0, i));
                long second = Long.parseLong(num.substring(i, j));
                if (check(first, second, j, num)) return true;
            }
        }
        return false;
    }
    private boolean check(long first, long second, int start, String num) {
        if (start == num.length()) return true;
        long sum = first + second;
        String sumStr = Long.toString(sum);
        if (!num.startsWith(sumStr, start)) return false;
        return check(second, sum, start + sumStr.length(), num);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n^3)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#314 Binary Tree Vertical Order Traversal

Description: Return node values ordered by column, then by row. **Intuition:** BFS tracking each node's column; collect values per column, then read columns left to right.

Variables: `columns` = column index to list of values · `queue / cols` = parallel BFS queues of nodes and their columns · `col` = current node's column · `min / max` = column range seen **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return []
enqueue root with col 0
while queue nonempty:
    node = poll, col = poll
    columns[col].add(node.val)
    update min, max
    if left: enqueue left with col-1
    if right: enqueue right with col+1
for col from min to max: result.add(columns[col])
return result

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> verticalOrder(TreeNode root) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Map<Integer, List<Integer>> columns = new HashMap<>();
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        Queue<Integer> cols = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        cols.offer(0);
        int min = 0, max = 0;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            TreeNode node = queue.poll();
            int col = cols.poll();
            columns.computeIfAbsent(col, k -> new ArrayList<>()).add(node.val);
            min = Math.min(min, col);
            max = Math.max(max, col);
            if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); cols.offer(col - 1); }
            if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); cols.offer(col + 1); }
        }
        for (int i = min; i <= max; i++) { result.add(columns.get(i)); }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#320 Generalized Abbreviation

Description: Return all abbreviations of a word (replace any non-adjacent groups of letters with their counts). **Intuition:** for each character, choose to either abbreviate it (extend a count) or keep it literally; backtrack.

Variables: `start` = current char index · `count` = pending run of abbreviated chars · `builder` = abbreviation being built
 · `len` = builder length to restore to **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(start=0, count=0)
if start at end:
    if count>0 append count; record; restore; return
backtrack(start+1, count+1) // abbreviate this char
save len; if count>0 append count; append word[start]
backtrack(start+1, 0) // keep this char
restore len

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> generateAbbreviations(String word) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(word, 0, 0, new StringBuilder(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(String word, int start, int count, StringBuilder builder, List<String> result) {
        if (start == word.length()) {
            int len = builder.length();
            if (count > 0) { builder.append(count); }
            result.add(builder.toString());
            builder.setLength(len);
            return;
        }
        backtrack(word, start + 1, count + 1, builder, result); // abbreviate this char
        int len = builder.length();
        if (count > 0) { builder.append(count); }
        builder.append(word.charAt(start));
        backtrack(word, start + 1, 0, builder, result); // keep this char
        builder.setLength(len);
    }
}

```

Time $O(2^n \cdot n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#339 Nested List Weight Sum

Description: Sum each integer in a nested list weighted by its depth. **Intuition:** DFS carrying the current depth; integers add $\text{value} \cdot \text{depth}$, lists recurse one level deeper.

Variables: `depth` = current nesting depth (root = 1) · `sum` = accumulated weighted sum at this level **Pseudocode:**

```

return dfs(list, depth=1)
dfs(list, depth):
    sum = 0
    for ni in list:
        if integer: sum += value * depth
        else: sum += dfs(ni.list, depth+1)
    return sum

```

```

class Solution {
    public int depthSum(List<NestedInteger> nestedList) {
        return dfs(nestedList, 1);
    }
    private int dfs(List<NestedInteger> list, int depth) {
        int sum = 0;
        for (NestedInteger ni : list) {
            if (ni.isInteger()) { sum += ni.getInteger() * depth; }
            else { sum += dfs(ni.getList(), depth + 1); }
        }
        return sum;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(d)$

#364 Nested List Weight Sum II

Description: Sum each integer weighted by its inverse depth (deepest integers have weight 1). **Intuition:** weight = (maxDepth – depth + 1). Accumulate sum of values at each level and a running unweighted total per BFS level so deeper values get counted more often.

Variables: `unweighted` = running sum of all integers seen through current level · `total` = answer accumulator · `queue` = BFS frontier · `size` = nodes in current level **Pseudocode:**

```
queue = nestedList
while queue nonempty:
    size = queue size
    for size items:
        ni = poll
        if integer: unweighted += value
        else: enqueue its list
    total += unweighted    // shallow values re-added each level
return total
```

```
class Solution {
    public int depthSumInverse(List<NestedInteger> nestedList) {
        int unweighted = 0, total = 0;
        Queue<NestedInteger> queue = new ArrayDeque<>(nestedList);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                NestedInteger ni = queue.poll();
                if (ni.isInteger()) { unweighted += ni.getInteger(); }
                else { queue.addAll(ni.getList()); }
            }
            total += unweighted;    // ← VARIATION: shallow values re-counted each level
        }
        return total;
    }
}
```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#386 Lexicographical Numbers

Description: Return integers 1..n in lexicographical order. **Intuition:** DFS a 10-ary prefix tree: start at each digit, append 0-9 as long as the number stays ≤ n.

Variables: `cur` = current number / prefix being visited · `n` = upper bound **Pseudocode:**

```
for i in 1..9: dfs(i)
dfs(cur):
    if cur > n: return
    record cur
    for digit in 0..9: dfs(cur*10 + digit)
```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> lexicalOrder(int n) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        for (int i = 1; i <= 9; i++) { dfs(i, n, result); }
        return result;
    }
    private void dfs(int cur, int n, List<Integer> result) {
        if (cur > n) return;
        result.add(cur);
        for (int i = 0; i <= 9; i++) { dfs(cur * 10 + i, n, result); }
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(\log n)$

#404 Sum of Left Leaves

Description: Sum the values of all left leaves in a binary tree. **Intuition:** pass down whether a node is a left child; add its value when it is both a left child and a leaf.

Variables: `isLeft` = whether current node is its parent's left child **Pseudocode:**

```

return dfs(root, false)
dfs(node, isLeft):
    if null: return 0
    if leaf: return isLeft ? node.val : 0
    return dfs(left, true) + dfs(right, false)

```

```

class Solution {
    public int sumOfLeftLeaves(TreeNode root) {
        return dfs(root, false);
    }
    private int dfs(TreeNode node, boolean isLeft) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        if (node.left == null && node.right == null) {
            return isLeft ? node.val : 0;
        }
        return dfs(node.left, true) + dfs(node.right, false);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#426 Convert Binary Search Tree to Sorted Doubly Linked List

Description: Convert a BST into a sorted circular doubly linked list in place. **Intuition:** inorder traversal yields sorted order; link each node to the previous one, then close the ring between head and tail.

Variables: `first` = head of list (smallest) · `last` = last node linked so far **Pseudocode:**


```

if root null: return null
inorder(root)
link last.right -> first and first.left -> last    // close ring
return first
inorder(node):
    if null: return
    recurse left
    if last exists: last.right=node, node.left=last
    else: first = node
    last = node
    recurse right

```

```

class Solution {
    private Node first = null, last = null;
    public Node treeToDoublyList(Node root) {
        if (root == null) return null;
        inorder(root);
        last.right = first;
        first.left = last;
        return first;
    }
    private void inorder(Node node) {
        if (node == null) return;
        inorder(node.left);
        if (last != null) { last.right = node; node.left = last; }
        else { first = node; }
        last = node;
        inorder(node.right);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#429 N-ary Tree Level Order Traversal

Description: Return the level order traversal of an N-ary tree. **Intuition:** BFS, enqueueing all children of each node per level.

Variables: `queue` = BFS frontier · `size` = nodes in current level · `level` = values collected for this level **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return []
enqueue root
while queue nonempty:
    size = queue size; level = []
    for size items:
        node = poll; level.add(node.val)
        enqueue all children
    result.add(level)
return result

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> levelOrder(Node root) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<Node> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            List<Integer> level = new ArrayList<>();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                Node node = queue.poll();
                level.add(node.val);
                for (Node child : node.children) { queue.offer(child); }
            }
            result.add(level);
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#437 Path Sum III

Description: Count downward paths (any node to any descendant) summing to a target. **Intuition:** prefix-sum the running root-to-node sum; the number of paths ending here equals how many earlier prefixes equal `current - target`.

Variables: `prefix` = map of root-to-node running sum to occurrence count · `current` = running sum down to this node
 · `count` = paths found in this subtree **Pseudocode:**

```

prefix[0] = 1
return dfs(root, 0, target)
dfs(node, current, target):
    if null: return 0
    current += node.val
    count = prefix[current - target] // paths ending here
    prefix[current]++
    count += dfs(left) + dfs(right)
    prefix[current]-- // backtrack
    return count

```

```

class Solution {
    public int pathSum(TreeNode root, int targetSum) {
        Map<Long, Integer> prefix = new HashMap<>();
        prefix.put(0L, 1);
        return dfs(root, 0L, targetSum, prefix);
    }
    private int dfs(TreeNode node, long current, int target, Map<Long, Integer> prefix) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        current += node.val;
        int count = prefix.getOrDefault(current - target, 0); // ← VARIATION: prefix-sum count
        prefix.merge(current, 1, Integer::sum);
        count += dfs(node.left, current, target, prefix);
        count += dfs(node.right, current, target, prefix);
        prefix.merge(current, -1, Integer::sum); // backtrack
        return count;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#440 K-th Smallest in Lexicographical Order

Description: Find the kth smallest integer in $1..n$ by lexicographical order. **Intuition:** count how many numbers share a prefix; skip whole subtrees of the 10-ary prefix tree when k exceeds their size, otherwise descend.

Variables: `cur` = current prefix in 10-ary tree · `k` = remaining steps to target · `steps` = count of numbers under prefix range $[first, last) \leq n$ **Pseudocode:**

```

cur = 1; k--
while k > 0:
    steps = countSteps(cur, cur+1)
    if steps <= k: move right sibling (cur++, k -= steps)
    else: descend (cur *= 10, k--)
return cur
countSteps(first, last):
    steps = 0
    while first <= n:
        steps += min(n+1, last) - first // count this level
        first *= 10; last *= 10
    return steps

```

```

class Solution {
    public int findKthNumber(int n, int k) {
        long cur = 1;
        k--;
        while (k > 0) {
            long steps = countSteps(n, cur, cur + 1);
            if (steps <= k) {
                cur++;
                k -= steps;
            } else {
                cur *= 10;
                k--;
            }
        }
        return (int) cur;
    }
    private long countSteps(int n, long first, long last) {
        long steps = 0;
        while (first <= n) {
            steps += Math.min((long) n + 1, last) - first;
            first *= 10;
            last *= 10;
        }
        return steps;
    }
}

```

Time $O(\log^2 n)$ | **Space** $O(1)$

#449 Serialize and Deserialize BST

Description: Serialize and deserialize a BST compactly. **Intuition:** preorder alone reconstructs a BST using value bounds, so no null markers are needed.

Variables: `builder` = preorder output · `tokens` = split values · `index` = next token to consume · `min / max` = allowed value bounds for current node **Pseudocode:**

```

serialize(node): if null return; append val+","; recurse left; recurse right
deserialize(data):
    if empty: return null
    tokens = split; index = 0
    return build(-inf, +inf)
build(min, max):
    if no tokens left: return null
    val = tokens[index]
    if val outside [min, max]: return null // belongs elsewhere
    index++
    node = new node(val)
    node.left = build(min, val); node.right = build(val, max)
    return node

```

```

public class Codec {
    public String serialize(TreeNode root) {
        StringBuilder builder = new StringBuilder();
        serialize(root, builder);
        return builder.toString();
    }
    private void serialize(TreeNode node, StringBuilder builder) {
        if (node == null) return;
        builder.append(node.val).append(',');
        serialize(node.left, builder);
        serialize(node.right, builder);
    }
    private int index = 0;
    private String[] tokens;
    public TreeNode deserialize(String data) {
        if (data.isEmpty()) return null;
        tokens = data.split(",");
        index = 0;
        return build(Integer.MIN_VALUE, Integer.MAX_VALUE);
    }
    private TreeNode build(int min, int max) {
        if (index == tokens.length) return null;
        int val = Integer.parseInt(tokens[index]);
        if (val < min || val > max) return null;
        index++;
        TreeNode node = new TreeNode(val);
        node.left = build(min, val);
        node.right = build(val, max);
        return node;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#450 Delete Node in a BST

Description: Delete a key from a BST and return the new root. **Intuition:** find the node; if it has two children, replace its value with the inorder successor (smallest in right subtree) and delete that successor.

Variables: `key` = value to delete · `successor` = smallest node in right subtree (inorder successor) **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return null
if key < root.val: root.left = delete(root.left, key)
else if key > root.val: root.right = delete(root.right, key)
else: // found node
    if no left child: return right
    if no right child: return left
    successor = leftmost of right subtree
    root.val = successor.val
    root.right = delete(root.right, successor.val)
return root

```

```

class Solution {
    public TreeNode deleteNode(TreeNode root, int key) {
        if (root == null) return null;
        if (key < root.val) {
            root.left = deleteNode(root.left, key);
        } else if (key > root.val) {
            root.right = deleteNode(root.right, key);
        } else {
            if (root.left == null) return root.right;
            if (root.right == null) return root.left;
            TreeNode successor = root.right;
            while (successor.left != null) { successor = successor.left; }
            root.val = successor.val;
            root.right = deleteNode(root.right, successor.val);
        }
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time O(h) | **Space** O(h)

#473 Matchsticks to Square

Description: Determine if matchsticks can form a square (4 equal sides) using all sticks. **Intuition:** backtrack placing each stick into one of 4 side buckets; prune when total isn't divisible by 4 or a stick exceeds the side length.

Variables: `total` = sum of sticks · `side` = target side length `total/4` · `sides[i]` = current length of bucket `i` · `index` = stick being placed (descending) **Pseudocode:**

```

total = sum; if not divisible by 4: return false
side = total/4; sort sticks
return backtrack(last index, sides=[0,0,0,0], side)
backtrack(index, sides, target):
    if index < 0: return all four sides == target
    for each bucket i in 0..3:
        if adding stick exceeds target: skip
        if bucket equals previous bucket (duplicate state): skip
        add stick to bucket i
        if backtrack(index-1): return true
        remove stick
    return false

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean makesquare(int[] matchsticks) {
        int total = 0;
        for (int stick : matchsticks) { total += stick; }
        if (total % 4 != 0) return false;
        int side = total / 4;
        Arrays.sort(matchsticks);
        return backtrack(matchsticks, matchsticks.length - 1, new int[4], side);
    }
    private boolean backtrack(int[] sticks, int index, int[] sides, int target) {
        if (index < 0) {
            return sides[0] == target && sides[1] == target && sides[2] == target;
        }
        for (int i = 0; i < 4; i++) {
            if (sides[i] + sticks[index] > target) continue;
            if (i > 0 && sides[i] == sides[i - 1]) continue; // ← VARIATION: skip equal buckets
            sides[i] += sticks[index];
            if (backtrack(sticks, index - 1, sides, target)) return true;
            sides[i] -= sticks[index];
        }
        return false;
    }
}

```

Time $O(4^n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#488 Zuma Game

Description: Find the minimum balls from hand to insert to clear the board (or -1). **Intuition:** DFS each board state, trying every hand ball at every insertion point, removing groups of 3+; memoize visited states.

Variables: board = current board · hand = sorted remaining balls · memo = state to min-steps · key = board+"#" + hand
 · best = min balls needed · next = board after inserting · remaining = hand minus used ball **Pseudocode:**

```

sort hand; result = dfs(board, hand)
return result == INF ? -1 : result
dfs(board, hand):
    if board empty: return 0
    if hand empty: return INF
    if key in memo: return it
    for each distinct hand ball i:
        for each insert position j in board:
            next = board with ball inserted at j, then removeGroups
            sub = dfs(next, hand without i)
            if sub finite: best = min(best, sub+1)
    memo[key] = best; return best
removeGroups(s): repeatedly find run of >=3 equal chars, remove it, restart

```

```

class Solution {
    public int findMinStep(String board, String hand) {
        char[] handArr = hand.toCharArray();
        Arrays.sort(handArr);
        int result = dfs(board, new String(handArr), new HashMap<>());
        return result == Integer.MAX_VALUE ? -1 : result;
    }

    private int dfs(String board, String hand, Map<String, Integer> memo) {
        if (board.isEmpty()) return 0;
        if (hand.isEmpty()) return Integer.MAX_VALUE;
        String key = board + "#" + hand;
        if (memo.containsKey(key)) return memo.get(key);
        int best = Integer.MAX_VALUE;
        for (int i = 0; i < hand.length(); i++) {
            if (i > 0 && hand.charAt(i) == hand.charAt(i - 1)) continue;
            for (int j = 0; j <= board.length(); j++) {
                String next = board.substring(0, j) + hand.charAt(i) + board.substring(j);
                next = removeGroups(next);
                String remaining = hand.substring(0, i) + hand.substring(i + 1);
                int sub = dfs(next, remaining, memo);
                if (sub != Integer.MAX_VALUE) { best = Math.min(best, sub + 1); }
            }
        }
        memo.put(key, best);
        return best;
    }

    private String removeGroups(String s) {
        int i = 0, n = s.length();
        while (i < n) {
            int j = i;
            while (j < n && s.charAt(j) == s.charAt(i)) { j++; }
            if (j - i >= 3) {
                return removeGroups(s.substring(0, i) + s.substring(j));
            }
            i = j;
        }
        return s;
    }
}

```

Time O(exponential) | **Space** O(states)

#489 Robot Room Cleaner

Description: Clean an entire room with a robot that has only relative move/turn/clean APIs and no map. **Intuition:** DFS with backtracking using relative coordinates; clean, try all four directions, and reverse-move to return after each branch.

Variables: `dr / dc` = direction deltas (up,right,down,left) · `r / c` = relative coords · `dir` = current facing · `visited` = cleaned cells · `nd / nr / nc` = next direction and cell **Pseudocode:**


```

backtrack(robot, 0, 0, 0, visited)
backtrack(r, c, dir):
    clean; mark (r,c) visited
    for i in 0..3:
        nd = (dir+i)%4; nr,nc = neighbor in dir nd
        if (nr,nc) unvisited and robot.move() succeeds:
            backtrack(nr, nc, nd)
            goBack()    // return to (r,c) facing dir
            turnRight
goBack: turn around, move, turn around again

```

```

class Solution {
    private static final int[] dr = {-1, 0, 1, 0};
    private static final int[] dc = {0, 1, 0, -1};
    public void cleanRoom(Robot robot) {
        backtrack(robot, 0, 0, 0, new HashSet<>());
    }
    private void backtrack(Robot robot, int r, int c, int dir, Set<String> visited) {
        robot.clean();
        visited.add(r + "," + c);
        for (int i = 0; i < 4; i++) {
            int nd = (dir + i) % 4;
            int nr = r + dr[nd];
            int nc = c + dc[nd];
            if (!visited.contains(nr + "," + nc) && robot.move()) {
                backtrack(robot, nr, nc, nd, visited);
                goBack(robot);
            }
            robot.turnRight();
        }
    }
    private void goBack(Robot robot) {
        robot.turnRight();
        robot.turnRight();
        robot.move();
        robot.turnRight();
        robot.turnRight();
    }
}

```

Time $O(\text{cells})$ | **Space** $O(\text{cells})$

#491 Increasing Subsequences

Description: Return all increasing subsequences of length ≥ 2 (input may have duplicates). **Intuition:** backtrack choosing elements $\geq$ the last picked; within one recursion level use a set to skip duplicate starts. Cannot sort (would destroy original order).

Variables: `start` = index to pick from · `path` = current subsequence · `used` = values already chosen at this level (dedup) **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(start=0, path=[])
if path size >= 2: record copy
used = empty set
for i from start to end:
    if path nonempty and nums[i] < last picked: skip
    if nums[i] already used this level: skip
    mark used; path.add(nums[i])
    backtrack(i+1, path)
    path.remove last

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> findSubsequences(int[] nums) {
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(nums, 0, new ArrayList<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(int[] nums, int start, List<Integer> path, List<List<Integer>> result) {
        if (path.size() >= 2) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(path)); }
        Set<Integer> used = new HashSet<>();
        for (int i = start; i < nums.length; i++) {
            if (!path.isEmpty() && nums[i] < path.get(path.size() - 1)) continue;
            if (used.contains(nums[i])) continue; // ← VARIATION: skip dup at same level
            used.add(nums[i]);
            path.add(nums[i]);
            backtrack(nums, i + 1, path, result);
            path.remove(path.size() - 1);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(2^n \cdot n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#501 Find Mode in Binary Search Tree

Description: Find the mode(s) (most frequent values) in a BST that may have duplicates. **Intuition:** inorder gives sorted values, so equal values are adjacent; track current run count and update the mode list when counts tie or exceed the max.

Variables: `prev` = previous inorder node · `count` = length of current equal-value run · `maxCount` = best run length · `modes` = values achieving `maxCount` **Pseudocode:**

```

inorder(root); copy modes to result array
inorder(node):
    if null: return
    recurse left
    if prev exists and same value: count++ else count = 1
    if count > maxCount: maxCount=count, modes=[node.val]
    else if count == maxCount: modes.add(node.val)
    prev = node
    recurse right

```

```

class Solution {
    private TreeNode prev = null;
    private int count = 0, maxCount = 0;
    private List<Integer> modes = new ArrayList<>();
    public int[] findMode(TreeNode root) {
        inorder(root);
        int[] result = new int[modes.size()];
        for (int i = 0; i < modes.size(); i++) { result[i] = modes.get(i); }
        return result;
    }
    private void inorder(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return;
        inorder(node.left);
        if (prev != null && prev.val == node.val) { count++; }
        else { count = 1; }
        if (count > maxCount) { maxCount = count; modes.clear(); modes.add(node.val); }
        else if (count == maxCount) { modes.add(node.val); }
        prev = node;
        inorder(node.right);
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(h)

#508 Most Frequent Subtree Sum

Description: Find the subtree sum(s) that occur most frequently. **Intuition:** post-order compute each subtree's sum, tally frequencies in a map, then collect the keys with the max frequency.

Variables: freq = subtree sum to occurrence count · maxFreq = highest frequency · sum = current subtree sum · f = updated count for this sum **Pseudocode:**

```

dfs(root)
collect all sums whose freq == maxFreq into result array
dfs(node):
    if null: return 0
    sum = node.val + dfs(left) + dfs(right)
    f = ++freq[sum]
    maxFreq = max(maxFreq, f)
    return sum

```

```

class Solution {
    private Map<Integer, Integer> freq = new HashMap<>();
    private int maxFreq = 0;
    public int[] findFrequentTreeSum(TreeNode root) {
        dfs(root);
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        for (Map.Entry<Integer, Integer> e : freq.entrySet()) {
            if (e.getValue() == maxFreq) { result.add(e.getKey()); }
        }
        int[] arr = new int[result.size()];
        for (int i = 0; i < result.size(); i++) { arr[i] = result.get(i); }
        return arr;
    }
    private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        int sum = node.val + dfs(node.left) + dfs(node.right);
        int f = freq.merge(sum, 1, Integer::sum);
        maxFreq = Math.max(maxFreq, f);
        return sum;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#510 Inorder Successor in BST II

Description: Find the inorder successor of a node given only a parent pointer (no root). **Intuition:** if a right subtree exists, the successor is its leftmost node; otherwise climb up until you come from a left child.

Variables: `node` = given node, walked toward successor **Pseudocode:**

```

if node has right child:
    node = node.right
    while node.left exists: node = node.left
    return node
while node has parent and node is parent's right child:
    node = node.parent
return node.parent

```

```

class Solution {
    public Node inorderSuccessor(Node node) {
        if (node.right != null) {
            node = node.right;
            while (node.left != null) { node = node.left; }
            return node;
        }
        while (node.parent != null && node == node.parent.right) {
            node = node.parent;
        }
        return node.parent;
    }
}

```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(1)$

#513 Find Bottom Left Tree Value

Description: Find the leftmost value in the last (deepest) row of a binary tree. **Intuition:** BFS scanning right-to-left so the final node dequeued is the bottom-left value.

Variables: `queue` = BFS frontier · `node` = last node dequeued (becomes bottom-left) **Pseudocode:**

```
enqueue root
while queue nonempty:
    node = poll
    if right child: enqueue right    // enqueue right before left
    if left child: enqueue left
return node.val    // last dequeued = deepest, leftmost
```

```
class Solution {
    public int findBottomLeftValue(TreeNode root) {
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        TreeNode node = root;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            node = queue.poll();
            if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
        }
        return node.val;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#515 Find Largest Value in Each Tree Row

Description: Return the maximum value in each row of a binary tree. **Intuition:** BFS level by level, tracking the max per level.

Variables: `queue` = BFS frontier · `size` = nodes in current level · `max` = max value in current level **Pseudocode:**

```
if root null: return []
enqueue root
while queue nonempty:
    size = queue size; max = -inf
    for size items:
        node = poll; max = max(max, node.val)
        enqueue left and right if present
    result.add(max)
return result
```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> largestValues(TreeNode root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            int max = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                max = Math.max(max, node.val);
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            }
            result.add(max);
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#526 Beautiful Arrangement

Description: Count permutations of $1..n$ where each number divides or is divisible by its position. **Intuition:** backtrack placing numbers position by position, only choosing a number when it satisfies the divisibility rule.

Variables: `count` = valid arrangements found · `pos` = position being filled (1-based) · `used[i]` = whether number i is placed **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(n, pos=1, used)
if pos > n: count++; return
for i in 1..n:
    if i unused and (i divisible by pos or pos divisible by i):
        mark i used
        backtrack(pos+1)
        unmark i

```

```

class Solution {
    private int count = 0;
    public int countArrangement(int n) {
        backtrack(n, 1, new boolean[n + 1]);
        return count;
    }
    private void backtrack(int n, int pos, boolean[] used) {
        if (pos > n) { count++; return; }
        for (int i = 1; i <= n; i++) {
            if (!used[i] && (i % pos == 0 || pos % i == 0)) {
                used[i] = true;
                backtrack(n, pos + 1, used);
                used[i] = false;
            }
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(k)$ where k = valid arrangements | **Space** $O(n)$

#536 Construct Binary Tree from String

Description: Build a binary tree from a string like `4(2(3)(1))(6(5))` . **Intuition:** parse the leading number as the node, then the first parenthesized group as the left subtree and the second as the right subtree.

Variables: `index` = current parse position · `start` = start of number token · `node` = node being built **Pseudocode:**

```
if s empty: return null
return build(s)
build(s):
    start = index
    if '-': advance
    while digit: advance
    node = new node(num[start..index])
    if next char '(':
        consume '('; node.left = build; consume ')'
    if next char '(':
        consume '('; node.right = build; consume ')'
    return node
```

```
class Solution {
    private int index = 0;
    public TreeNode str2tree(String s) {
        if (s.isEmpty()) return null;
        return build(s);
    }
    private TreeNode build(String s) {
        int start = index;
        if (s.charAt(index) == '-') { index++; }
        while (index < s.length() && Character.isDigit(s.charAt(index))) { index++; }
        TreeNode node = new TreeNode(Integer.parseInt(s.substring(start, index)));
        if (index < s.length() && s.charAt(index) == '(') {
            index++; // consume '('
            node.left = build(s);
            index++; // consume ')'
        }
        if (index < s.length() && s.charAt(index) == '(') {
            index++;
            node.right = build(s);
            index++;
        }
        return node;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#538 Convert BST to Greater Tree

Description: Replace each node's value with the sum of all values greater than or equal to it. **Intuition:** reverse inorder (right $\rightarrow$ node $\rightarrow$ left) visits values in descending order; carry a running sum and add it into each node.

Variables: `sum` = running total of all values visited so far (descending) · `root` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```
if root null: return null
recurse right
sum += root.val
root.val = sum
recurse left
return root
```

```
class Solution {
    private int sum = 0;
    public TreeNode convertBST(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return null;
        convertBST(root.right);
        sum += root.val;
        root.val = sum;
        convertBST(root.left);
        return root;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#545 Boundary of Binary Tree

Description: Return the boundary: root, left boundary top-down, leaves left-to-right, right boundary bottom-up, no duplicates. **Intuition:** collect three parts separately — left boundary (excluding leaves), all leaves, and right boundary reversed (excluding leaves).

Variables: `result` = boundary values in order · `node` = current node · `temp` = right-boundary values collected top-down (later reversed) **Pseudocode:**


```
if root null: return result
if root not leaf: add root.val
addLeftBoundary(root.left)
addLeaves(root)
addRightBoundary(root.right)
return result
```

isLeaf: both children null

```
addLeftBoundary(node):
  while node != null:
    if node not leaf: add node.val
    node = left if exists else right
```

```
addLeaves(node):
  if null: return
  if leaf: add node.val; return
  recurse left, recurse right
```

```
addRightBoundary(node):
  while node != null:
    if node not leaf: temp.add(node.val)
    node = right if exists else left
  reverse temp; add all to result
```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> boundaryOfBinaryTree(TreeNode root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (root == null) return result;
        if (!isLeaf(root)) { result.add(root.val); }
        addLeftBoundary(root.left, result);
        addLeaves(root, result);
        addRightBoundary(root.right, result);
        return result;
    }
    private boolean isLeaf(TreeNode node) {
        return node.left == null && node.right == null;
    }
    private void addLeftBoundary(TreeNode node, List<Integer> result) {
        while (node != null) {
            if (!isLeaf(node)) { result.add(node.val); }
            node = node.left != null ? node.left : node.right;
        }
    }
    private void addLeaves(TreeNode node, List<Integer> result) {
        if (node == null) return;
        if (isLeaf(node)) { result.add(node.val); return; }
        addLeaves(node.left, result);
        addLeaves(node.right, result);
    }
    private void addRightBoundary(TreeNode node, List<Integer> result) {
        List<Integer> temp = new ArrayList<>();
        while (node != null) {
            if (!isLeaf(node)) { temp.add(node.val); }
            node = node.right != null ? node.right : node.left;
        }
        Collections.reverse(temp);
        result.addAll(temp);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#559 Maximum Depth of N-ary Tree

Description: Find the maximum depth of an N-ary tree. **Intuition:** depth is 1 plus the max depth among all children.

Variables: `root` = current node · `max` = deepest child depth seen **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return 0
max = 0
for each child: max = max(max, maxDepth(child))
return max + 1

```

```

class Solution {
    public int maxDepth(Node root) {
        if (root == null) return 0;
        int max = 0;
        for (Node child : root.children) {
            max = Math.max(max, maxDepth(child));
        }
        return max + 1;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | Space $O(h)$

#563 Binary Tree Tilt

Description: Sum the tilt of every node, where tilt = $|\text{left subtree sum} - \text{right subtree sum}|$. **Intuition:** post-order return each subtree sum; accumulate the absolute difference into a global total.

Variables: `total` = accumulated tilt across all nodes · `left` / `right` = subtree sums **Pseudocode:**

```
sum(root); return total
```

```
sum(node):  
    if null: return 0  
    left = sum(node.left)  
    right = sum(node.right)  
    total += |left - right|  
    return left + right + node.val
```

```
class Solution {  
    private int total = 0;  
    public int findTilt(TreeNode root) {  
        sum(root);  
        return total;  
    }  
    private int sum(TreeNode node) {  
        if (node == null) return 0;  
        int left = sum(node.left);  
        int right = sum(node.right);  
        total += Math.abs(left - right);  
        return left + right + node.val;  
    }  
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | Space $O(h)$

#572 Subtree of Another Tree

Description: Check whether `subRoot` is a subtree of `root`. **Intuition:** at every node of `root`, test for structural equality with `subRoot`.

Variables: `root` = current node of main tree · `subRoot` = pattern tree root · `a` / `b` = nodes compared for equality

Pseudocode:

```
isSubtree(root, subRoot):  
    if root null: return false  
    if isSame(root, subRoot): return true  
    return isSubtree(left) or isSubtree(right)  
  
isSame(a, b):  
    if both null: return true  
    if one null: return false  
    if a.val != b.val: return false  
    return isSame(lefts) and isSame(rights)
```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean isSubtree(TreeNode root, TreeNode subRoot) {
        if (root == null) return false;
        if (isSame(root, subRoot)) return true;
        return isSubtree(root.left, subRoot) || isSubtree(root.right, subRoot);
    }
    private boolean isSame(TreeNode a, TreeNode b) {
        if (a == null && b == null) return true;
        if (a == null || b == null) return false;
        if (a.val != b.val) return false;
        return isSame(a.left, b.left) && isSame(a.right, b.right);
    }
}

```

Time $O(m \cdot n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#589 N-ary Tree Preorder Traversal

Description: Return the preorder traversal of an N-ary tree. **Intuition:** visit the node, then recurse into each child in order.

Variables: `result` = preorder values · `node` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```
dfs(root, result); return result
```

```

dfs(node):
    if null: return
    add node.val
    for each child: dfs(child)

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> preorder(Node root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        dfs(root, result);
        return result;
    }
    private void dfs(Node node, List<Integer> result) {
        if (node == null) return;
        result.add(node.val);
        for (Node child : node.children) { dfs(child, result); }
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#590 N-ary Tree Postorder Traversal

Description: Return the postorder traversal of an N-ary tree. **Intuition:** recurse into all children first, then visit the node.

Variables: `result` = postorder values · `node` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```
dfs(root, result); return result
```

```

dfs(node):
    if null: return
    for each child: dfs(child)
    add node.val

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> postorder(Node root) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        dfs(root, result);
        return result;
    }
    private void dfs(Node node, List<Integer> result) {
        if (node == null) return;
        for (Node child : node.children) { dfs(child, result); }
        result.add(node.val);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#606 Construct String from Binary Tree

Description: Build a preorder string with parentheses, e.g. `1(2(4))(3)` . **Intuition:** append the value, then each non-null child wrapped in parentheses; keep empty `()` for a left child only when a right child exists.

Variables: `builder` = output string buffer · `node` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```

dfs(root, builder); return builder

dfs(node):
    if null: return
    append node.val
    if leaf: return
    append '('; dfs(left); append ')'
    if right != null:
        append '('; dfs(right); append ')'

```

```

class Solution {
    public String tree2str(TreeNode root) {
        StringBuilder builder = new StringBuilder();
        dfs(root, builder);
        return builder.toString();
    }
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, StringBuilder builder) {
        if (node == null) return;
        builder.append(node.val);
        if (node.left == null && node.right == null) return;
        builder.append('(');
        dfs(node.left, builder);
        builder.append(')');
        if (node.right != null) {
            builder.append('(');
            dfs(node.right, builder);
            builder.append(')');
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#617 Merge Two Binary Trees

Description: Merge two binary trees by summing overlapping node values. **Intuition:** if either node is null, return the other; otherwise sum values and recurse on both child pairs.

Variables: `root1 / root2` = current nodes of the two trees · `merged` = new combined node **Pseudocode:**

```
if root1 null: return root2
if root2 null: return root1
merged = node(root1.val + root2.val)
merged.left = merge(root1.left, root2.left)
merged.right = merge(root1.right, root2.right)
return merged
```

```
class Solution {
    public TreeNode mergeTrees(TreeNode root1, TreeNode root2) {
        if (root1 == null) return root2;
        if (root2 == null) return root1;
        TreeNode merged = new TreeNode(root1.val + root2.val);
        merged.left = mergeTrees(root1.left, root2.left);
        merged.right = mergeTrees(root1.right, root2.right);
        return merged;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#637 Average of Levels in Binary Tree

Description: Return the average value of nodes on each level. **Intuition:** BFS each level, summing values and dividing by the level size.

Variables: `queue` = BFS queue · `size` = nodes on current level · `sum` = level value sum · `result` = per-level averages

Pseudocode:

```
offer root
while queue not empty:
    size = queue.size; sum = 0
    repeat size times:
        node = poll; sum += node.val
    offer non-null children
    result.add(sum / size)
return result
```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Double> averageOfLevels(TreeNode root) {
        List<Double> result = new ArrayList<>();
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            double sum = 0;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                sum += node.val;
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            }
            result.add(sum / size);
        }
        return result;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#652 Find Duplicate Subtrees

Description: Return one root per group of structurally identical, duplicated subtrees. **Intuition:** serialize each subtree post-order into a canonical string; the second time a serialization appears, record its root.

Variables: `seen` = serialization $\rightarrow$ occurrence count · `result` = one root per duplicate group · `key` = canonical serialization of subtree · `count` = occurrences of key **Pseudocode:**

```

serialize(root, seen, result); return result

```

```

serialize(node):
    if null: return "#"
    key = node.val + "," + serialize(left) + "," + serialize(right)
    count = seen.merge(key, +1)
    if count == 2: result.add(node)
    return key

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<TreeNode> findDuplicateSubtrees(TreeNode root) {
        List<TreeNode> result = new ArrayList<>();
        serialize(root, new HashMap<>(), result);
        return result;
    }
    private String serialize(TreeNode node, Map<String, Integer> seen, List<TreeNode> result) {
        if (node == null) return "#";
        String key = node.val + "," + serialize(node.left, seen, result) + "," + serialize(node.right,
        int count = seen.merge(key, 1, Integer::sum);
        if (count == 2) { result.add(node); }
        return key;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n^2)$ | **Space** $O(n^2)$

#653 Two Sum IV - Input is a BST

Description: Find whether two nodes in a BST sum to a target. **Intuition:** traverse, storing seen values in a set; for each node check if `target - val` was seen.

Variables: `k` = target sum · `seen` = values visited so far · `node` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```
return dfs(root, k, empty set)

dfs(node):
    if null: return false
    if seen contains k - node.val: return true
    seen.add(node.val)
    return dfs(left) or dfs(right)
```

```
class Solution {
    public boolean findTarget(TreeNode root, int k) {
        return dfs(root, k, new HashSet<>());
    }
    private boolean dfs(TreeNode node, int k, Set<Integer> seen) {
        if (node == null) return false;
        if (seen.contains(k - node.val)) return true;
        seen.add(node.val);
        return dfs(node.left, k, seen) || dfs(node.right, k, seen);
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#654 Maximum Binary Tree

Description: Build a tree where the root is the array max, left subtree from the left subarray, right subtree from the right subarray. **Intuition:** find the max in the range as root, recurse on the two halves.

Variables: range `[lo, hi]` = subarray under construction · `maxIndex` = index of max in range · `root` = node for that max **Pseudocode:**

```
return build(nums, 0, n-1)

build(lo, hi):
    if lo > hi: return null
    maxIndex = lo
    for i in lo+1..hi: if nums[i] > nums[maxIndex]: maxIndex = i
    root = node(nums[maxIndex])
    root.left = build(lo, maxIndex-1)
    root.right = build(maxIndex+1, hi)
    return root
```



```

class Solution {
    public TreeNode constructMaximumBinaryTree(int[] nums) {
        return build(nums, 0, nums.length - 1);
    }
    private TreeNode build(int[] nums, int lo, int hi) {
        if (lo > hi) return null;
        int maxIndex = lo;
        for (int i = lo + 1; i <= hi; i++) {
            if (nums[i] > nums[maxIndex]) { maxIndex = i; }
        }
        TreeNode root = new TreeNode(nums[maxIndex]);
        root.left = build(nums, lo, maxIndex - 1);
        root.right = build(nums, maxIndex + 1, hi);
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n^2)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#662 Maximum Width of Binary Tree

Description: Return the maximum width of any level, where width counts the gap between the leftmost and rightmost non-null nodes. **Intuition:** assign heap-style indices (left = $2i$, right = $2i+1$); per level the width is last index – first index + 1.

Variables: queue = node BFS queue · indices = heap-style index per node (left= $2i$, right= $2i+1$) · first / last = leftmost/rightmost index this level · max = widest level **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return 0
offer root with index 0
while queue not empty:
    size = queue.size
    for i in 0..size-1:
        node = poll; index = indices.poll
        if i == 0: first = index
        if i == size-1: last = index
        offer left with 2*index, right with 2*index+1 (if non-null)
    max = max(max, last - first + 1)
return max

```

```

class Solution {
    public int widthOfBinaryTree(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return 0;
        int max = 0;
        Queue queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        Queue<Integer> indices = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        indices.offer(0);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            int first = 0, last = 0;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                int index = indices.poll();
                if (i == 0) { first = index; }
                if (i == size - 1) { last = index; }
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); indices.offer(2 * index); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); indices.offer(2 * index + 1); }
            }
            max = Math.max(max, last - first + 1);
        }
        return max;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#671 Second Minimum Node In a Binary Tree

Description: In a tree where each node's value is the min of its children, find the second smallest value overall. **Intuition:** the root is the global minimum; DFS for the smallest value strictly greater than the root.

Variables: `min` = root value (global minimum) · `second` = smallest value strictly greater than min · `left / right` = recursive results **Pseudocode:**

```

second = dfs(root, root.val)
return second == MAX ? -1 : second

dfs(node, min):
    if null: return MAX
    if node.val > min: return node.val
    left = dfs(left, min); right = dfs(right, min)
    return min(left, right)

```

```

class Solution {
    public int findSecondMinimumValue(TreeNode root) {
        long second = dfs(root, root.val);
        return second == Long.MAX_VALUE ? -1 : (int) second;
    }
    private long dfs(TreeNode node, int min) {
        if (node == null) return Long.MAX_VALUE;
        if (node.val > min) return node.val;
        long left = dfs(node.left, min);
        long right = dfs(node.right, min);
        return Math.min(left, right);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#679 24 Game

Description: Determine if four numbers can be combined with +, −, ×, ÷ to make 24. **Intuition:** backtrack: pick any two numbers, apply each operator, replace them with the result, and recurse until one number remains.

Variables: `nums / list` = current numbers as doubles · `i, j` = indices of the two picked numbers · `next` = remaining numbers plus result · `value` = result of one operation **Pseudocode:**

```
convert cards to doubles; return backtrack(list)

backtrack(nums):
    if size == 1: return |nums[0] - 24| < eps
    for i in nums, for j in nums, i != j:
        next = all nums except i, j
        for each value in compute(nums[i], nums[j]):
            next.add(value)
            if backtrack(next): return true
        next.remove last
    return false

compute(a, b): {a+b, a-b, a*b, and a/b if b != 0}
```

```
class Solution {
    public boolean judgePoint24(int[] cards) {
        List<Double> list = new ArrayList<>();
        for (int card : cards) { list.add((double) card); }
        return backtrack(list);
    }
    private boolean backtrack(List<Double> nums) {
        if (nums.size() == 1) { return Math.abs(nums.get(0) - 24) < 1e-6; }
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.size(); i++) {
            for (int j = 0; j < nums.size(); j++) {
                if (i == j) continue;
                List<Double> next = new ArrayList<>();
                for (int k = 0; k < nums.size(); k++) {
                    if (k != i && k != j) { next.add(nums.get(k)); }
                }
                for (double value : compute(nums.get(i), nums.get(j))) {
                    next.add(value);
                    if (backtrack(next)) return true;
                    next.remove(next.size() - 1);
                }
            }
        }
        return false;
    }
    private List<Double> compute(double a, double b) {
        List<Double> result = new ArrayList<>(Arrays.asList(a + b, a - b, a * b));
        if (Math.abs(b) > 1e-6) { result.add(a / b); }
        return result;
    }
}
```

Time $O(1)$ (bounded) | **Space** $O(1)$

#698 Partition to K Equal Sum Subsets

Description: Determine if an array can be split into k subsets of equal sum. **Intuition:** target = total/k; backtrack filling one bucket at a time, sorting descending to fail fast, skipping when total isn't divisible.

Variables: total = sum of nums · target = total/k bucket size · used[i] = number i already placed · index = current scan start · current = current bucket sum · k = buckets remaining **Pseudocode:**

```
total = sum; if total % k != 0: return false
target = total/k; sort nums
if largest > target: return false
return backtrack(n-1, used, k, 0, target)

backtrack(index, used, k, current, target):
    if k == 0: return true
    if current == target: return backtrack(n-1, used, k-1, 0, target)
    for i from index down to 0:
        if used[i] or current+nums[i] > target: continue
        used[i] = true
        if backtrack(i-1, used, k, current+nums[i], target): return true
        used[i] = false
    return false
```

```
class Solution {
    public boolean canPartitionKSubsets(int[] nums, int k) {
        int total = 0;
        for (int num : nums) { total += num; }
        if (total % k != 0) return false;
        int target = total / k;
        Arrays.sort(nums);
        if (nums[nums.length - 1] > target) return false;
        return backtrack(nums, nums.length - 1, new boolean[nums.length], k, 0, target);
    }
    private boolean backtrack(int[] nums, int index, boolean[] used, int k, int current, int target) {
        if (k == 0) return true;
        if (current == target) {
            return backtrack(nums, nums.length - 1, used, k - 1, 0, target);
        }
        for (int i = index; i >= 0; i--) {
            if (used[i] || current + nums[i] > target) continue;
            used[i] = true;
            if (backtrack(nums, i - 1, used, k, current + nums[i], target)) return true;
            used[i] = false;
        }
        return false;
    }
}
```

Time $O(k \cdot 2^n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#700 Search in a Binary Search Tree

Description: Find the subtree rooted at the node with a given value in a BST. **Intuition:** binary-search the tree: go left if target is smaller, right if larger.

Variables: root = current node · val = target value **Pseudocode:**

```
while root != null and root.val != val:
    root = left if val < root.val else right
return root
```

```
class Solution {
    public TreeNode searchBST(TreeNode root, int val) {
        while (root != null && root.val != val) {
            root = val < root.val ? root.left : root.right;
        }
        return root;
    }
}
```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(1)$

#701 Insert into a Binary Search Tree

Description: Insert a value into a BST and return the root. **Intuition:** descend like a search until reaching a null child, then attach a new node there.

Variables: `root` = current node · `val` = value to insert **Pseudocode:**

```
if root null: return new node(val)
if val < root.val: root.left = insert(root.left, val)
else: root.right = insert(root.right, val)
return root
```

```
class Solution {
    public TreeNode insertIntoBST(TreeNode root, int val) {
        if (root == null) return new TreeNode(val);
        if (val < root.val) { root.left = insertIntoBST(root.left, val); }
        else { root.right = insertIntoBST(root.right, val); }
        return root;
    }
}
```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#742 Closest Leaf in a Binary Tree

Description: Find the value of the leaf nearest to the node with a given value. **Intuition:** convert the tree to an undirected graph, then BFS from the target node until the first leaf is reached.

Variables: `graph` = node $\rightarrow$ neighbor list (undirected) · `start[0]` = node with value `k` · `queue / visited` = BFS state · `k` = target value **Pseudocode:**

```

buildGraph(root, null, graph, k, start)
BFS from start[0]:
    node = poll
    if node is leaf: return node.val
    for each neighbor: if newly visited, offer
return -1

buildGraph(node, parent):
    if null: return
    if node.val == k: start[0] = node
    if parent != null: add edges node<->parent
    recurse left (parent=node), recurse right (parent=node)

```

```

class Solution {
    public int findClosestLeaf(TreeNode root, int k) {
        Map<TreeNode, List<TreeNode>> graph = new HashMap<>();
        TreeNode[] start = new TreeNode[1];
        buildGraph(root, null, graph, k, start);
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        Set<TreeNode> visited = new HashSet<>();
        queue.offer(start[0]);
        visited.add(start[0]);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            TreeNode node = queue.poll();
            if (node.left == null && node.right == null) { return node.val; }
            for (TreeNode neighbor : graph.getOrDefault(node, new ArrayList<>())) {
                if (visited.add(neighbor)) { queue.offer(neighbor); }
            }
        }
        return -1;
    }

    private void buildGraph(TreeNode node, TreeNode parent, Map<TreeNode, List<TreeNode>> graph, int k,
        if (node == null) return;
        if (node.val == k) { start[0] = node; }
        if (parent != null) {
            graph.computeIfAbsent(node, x -> new ArrayList<>()).add(parent);
            graph.computeIfAbsent(parent, x -> new ArrayList<>()).add(node);
        }
        buildGraph(node.left, node, graph, k, start);
        buildGraph(node.right, node, graph, k, start);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#776 Split BST

Description: Split a BST into two trees: one with values $\leq V$ and one with values $> V$. **Intuition:** recurse; at each node decide which result tree it belongs to based on V , then reattach the recursively-split child.

Variables: `root` = current node · `target` = split value · returned pair `[ $\leq$ target tree,  $>$ target tree]` · `left / right` = recursive split pairs **Pseudocode:**

```

if root == null: return [null, null]
if root.val <= target:
    right = split(root.right, target)
    root.right = right[0]
    return [root, right[1]]
else:
    left = split(root.left, target)
    root.left = left[1]
    return [left[0], root]

```

```

class Solution {
    public TreeNode[] splitBST(TreeNode root, int target) {
        if (root == null) return new TreeNode[]{null, null};
        if (root.val <= target) {
            TreeNode[] right = splitBST(root.right, target);
            root.right = right[0];
            return new TreeNode[]{root, right[1]};
        } else {
            TreeNode[] left = splitBST(root.left, target);
            root.left = left[1];
            return new TreeNode[]{left[0], root};
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#784 Letter Case Permutation

Description: Return all strings formable by toggling the case of letters in a string. **Intuition:** backtrack character by character; digits have one choice, letters branch into lower and upper case.

Variables: `arr` = mutable char array · `start` = index being decided · `result` = all permutations **Pseudocode:**

```

backtrack(chars, 0, result); return result

backtrack(arr, start):
    if start == length: add new String(arr); return
    if arr[start] is letter:
        set lowercase; backtrack(start+1)
        set uppercase; backtrack(start+1)
    else:
        backtrack(start+1)

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<String> letterCasePermutation(String s) {
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(s.toCharArray(), 0, result);
        return result;
    }
    private void backtrack(char[] arr, int start, List<String> result) {
        if (start == arr.length) { result.add(new String(arr)); return; }
        if (Character.isLetter(arr[start])) {
            arr[start] = Character.toLowerCase(arr[start]);
            backtrack(arr, start + 1, result);
            arr[start] = Character.toUpperCase(arr[start]);
            backtrack(arr, start + 1, result);
        } else {
            backtrack(arr, start + 1, result);
        }
    }
}

```

Time $O(2^n \cdot n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#814 Binary Tree Pruning

Description: Remove every subtree that contains no node with value 1. **Intuition:** post-order prune children first; drop a node if both children become null and its own value is 0.

Variables: `root` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return null
root.left = prune(root.left)
root.right = prune(root.right)
if both children null and root.val == 0: return null
return root

```

```

class Solution {
    public TreeNode pruneTree(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return null;
        root.left = pruneTree(root.left);
        root.right = pruneTree(root.right);
        if (root.left == null && root.right == null && root.val == 0) {
            return null;
        }
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#842 Split Array into Fibonacci Sequence

Description: Split a digit string into a Fibonacci-like sequence (each term = sum of previous two), with terms fitting in a 32-bit int. **Intuition:** backtrack the first two numbers; the rest is forced. Prune leading zeros and overflow.

Variables: `path` = sequence built so far · `start` = current split position · `i` = end index of current number · `value` = parsed number · `size` = path length **Pseudocode:**


```
backtrack(num, 0, result); return result
```

```
backtrack(start, path):
    if start == length: return path.size >= 3
    for i from start to end:
        if leading zero (num[start]=='0' and i>start): break
        value = parse num[start..i]
        if value > INT_MAX: break
        if size >= 2 and value > path[-1]+path[-2]: break
        if size < 2 or value == path[-1]+path[-2]:
            path.add(value)
            if backtrack(i+1, path): return true
            path.remove last
    return false
```

```
class Solution {
    public List<Integer> splitIntoFibonacci(String num) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(num, 0, result);
        return result;
    }
    private boolean backtrack(String num, int start, List<Integer> path) {
        if (start == num.length()) { return path.size() >= 3; }
        for (int i = start; i < num.length(); i++) {
            if (num.charAt(start) == '0' && i > start) break; // no leading zero
            long value = Long.parseLong(num.substring(start, i + 1));
            if (value > Integer.MAX_VALUE) break;
            int size = path.size();
            if (size >= 2 && value > (long) path.get(size - 1) + path.get(size - 2)) break;
            if (size < 2 || value == (long) path.get(size - 1) + path.get(size - 2)) {
                path.add((int) value);
                if (backtrack(num, i + 1, path)) return true;
                path.remove(path.size() - 1);
            }
        }
        return false;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n^2)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#863 All Nodes Distance K in Binary Tree

Description: Find all node values exactly distance k from a target node. **Intuition:** build parent links so the tree becomes an undirected graph, then BFS k levels from the target.

Variables: parent = node $\rightarrow$ its parent · queue / visited = BFS state · dist = current distance from target · k = target distance **Pseudocode:**

```

buildParents(root, null, parent)
offer target; visited.add(target); dist = 0
while queue not empty:
    if dist == k: break
    for each node in current level:
        for neighbor in {left, right, parent}:
            if non-null and newly visited: offer
    dist++
collect remaining queue values into result; return result

buildParents(node, par): record parent, recurse children

```

```

class Solution {
    public List<Integer> distanceK(TreeNode root, TreeNode target, int k) {
        Map<TreeNode, TreeNode> parent = new HashMap<>();
        buildParents(root, null, parent);
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        Set<TreeNode> visited = new HashSet<>();
        queue.offer(target);
        visited.add(target);
        int dist = 0;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            if (dist == k) break;
            int size = queue.size();
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                for (TreeNode neighbor : new TreeNode[]{node.left, node.right, parent.get(node)}) {
                    if (neighbor != null && visited.add(neighbor)) { queue.offer(neighbor); }
                }
            }
            dist++;
        }
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        for (TreeNode node : queue) { result.add(node.val); }
        return result;
    }
    private void buildParents(TreeNode node, TreeNode par, Map<TreeNode, TreeNode> parent) {
        if (node == null) return;
        parent.put(node, par);
        buildParents(node.left, node, parent);
        buildParents(node.right, node, parent);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#865 Smallest Subtree with all the Deepest Nodes

Description: Find the smallest subtree containing all of the tree's deepest leaves. **Intuition:** post-order return (depth, lca). If left and right depths tie, the current node is the LCA; otherwise carry up the deeper side.

Variables: `Result.depth` = subtree height · `Result.node` = LCA of deepest nodes in subtree · `left / right` = child results
Pseudocode:

```
return dfs(root).node
```

```
dfs(node):  
    if null: return Result(0, null)  
    left = dfs(left); right = dfs(right)  
    if left.depth == right.depth: return Result(left.depth+1, node)  
    return deeper side's node with depth+1
```

```
class Solution {  
    public TreeNode subtreeWithAllDeepest(TreeNode root) {  
        return dfs(root).node;  
    }  
    private Result dfs(TreeNode node) {  
        if (node == null) return new Result(0, null);  
        Result left = dfs(node.left);  
        Result right = dfs(node.right);  
        if (left.depth == right.depth) {  
            return new Result(left.depth + 1, node); // ← VARIATION: tie → this node is LCA  
        }  
        return left.depth > right.depth  
            ? new Result(left.depth + 1, left.node)  
            : new Result(right.depth + 1, right.node);  
    }  
    private static class Result {  
        int depth;  
        TreeNode node;  
        Result(int depth, TreeNode node) { this.depth = depth; this.node = node; }  
    }  
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#889 Construct Binary Tree from Preorder and Postorder Traversal

Description: Reconstruct a binary tree from preorder and postorder traversals (any valid tree). **Intuition:** preorder[start] is the root; preorder[start+1] is the left subtree root, whose position in postorder gives the left subtree size.

Variables: `preIndex` = pointer into preorder · `postIndex` = pointer into postorder · `root` = node built from current preorder value **Pseudocode:**

```
root = node(preorder[preIndex++])  
if root.val != postorder[postIndex]: root.left = recurse  
if root.val != postorder[postIndex]: root.right = recurse  
postIndex++  
return root
```

```

class Solution {
    private int preIndex = 0, postIndex = 0;
    public TreeNode constructFromPrePost(int[] preorder, int[] postorder) {
        TreeNode root = new TreeNode(preorder[preIndex++]);
        if (root.val != postorder[postIndex]) {
            root.left = constructFromPrePost(preorder, postorder);
        }
        if (root.val != postorder[postIndex]) {
            root.right = constructFromPrePost(preorder, postorder);
        }
        postIndex++;
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#897 Increasing Order Search Tree

Description: Rearrange a BST into a right-skewed tree following inorder order. **Intuition:** inorder traversal; relink each node as the right child of the previous, clearing left pointers.

Variables: `current` = tail of the rebuilt right-skewed list · `dummy` = sentinel before first node · `node` = current node in inorder **Pseudocode:**

```

dummy = node(0); current = dummy
inorder(root)
return dummy.right

inorder(node):
    if null: return
    inorder(left)
    node.left = null
    current.right = node; current = node
    inorder(right)

```

```

class Solution {
    private TreeNode current;
    public TreeNode increasingBST(TreeNode root) {
        TreeNode dummy = new TreeNode(0);
        current = dummy;
        inorder(root);
        return dummy.right;
    }
    private void inorder(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return;
        inorder(node.left);
        node.left = null;
        current.right = node;
        current = node;
        inorder(node.right);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#919 Complete Binary Tree Inserter

Description: Design a structure that supports $O(1)$ insertion into a complete binary tree. **Intuition:** keep a BFS queue of nodes that still have a free child slot; insert into the front node and enqueue the new node.

Variables: `root` = tree root · `queue` = nodes with a free child slot (front = next insert point) · `bfs` = init traversal queue · `parent` = node receiving the new child **Pseudocode:**

```
constructor(root):
    BFS all nodes; enqueue any node missing a child into queue

insert(val):
    node = new node(val)
    parent = queue.peek
    if parent.left == null: parent.left = node
    else: parent.right = node; queue.poll
    queue.offer(node)
    return parent.val

get_root: return root
```

```
class CBTInserter {
    private TreeNode root;
    private Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
    public CBTInserter(TreeNode root) {
        this.root = root;
        Queue<TreeNode> bfs = new ArrayDeque<>();
        bfs.offer(root);
        while (!bfs.isEmpty()) {
            TreeNode node = bfs.poll();
            if (node.left != null) { bfs.offer(node.left); }
            if (node.right != null) { bfs.offer(node.right); }
            if (node.left == null || node.right == null) { queue.offer(node); }
        }
    }
    public int insert(int val) {
        TreeNode node = new TreeNode(val);
        TreeNode parent = queue.peek();
        if (parent.left == null) { parent.left = node; }
        else { parent.right = node; queue.poll(); }
        queue.offer(node);
        return parent.val;
    }
    public TreeNode get_root() { return root; }
}
```

Time $O(1)$ insert | **Space** $O(n)$

#932 Beautiful Array

Description: Construct an array of $1..n$ where no three indices $i < j < k$ satisfy $2 \cdot a[j] = a[i] + a[k]$. **Intuition:** divide and conquer: a beautiful array of odds followed by evens stays beautiful, since odd + even is never twice an integer.

Variables: `result` = current beautiful array · `next` = next-round array (odds-mapped then evens-mapped) · `x` = element being transformed · `arr` = final output **Pseudocode:**

```

result = [1]
while result.size < n:
    next = []
    for x in result: if 2x-1 <= n: next.add(2x-1)    // odds
    for x in result: if 2x <= n: next.add(2x)        // evens
    result = next
copy result into arr; return arr

```

```

class Solution {
    public int[] beautifulArray(int n) {
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        result.add(1);
        while (result.size() < n) {
            List<Integer> next = new ArrayList<>();
            for (int x : result) { if (2 * x - 1 <= n) { next.add(2 * x - 1); } } // odds
            for (int x : result) { if (2 * x <= n) { next.add(2 * x); } } // evens
            result = next;
        }
        int[] arr = new int[n];
        for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) { arr[i] = result.get(i); }
        return arr;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n \log n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#938 Range Sum of BST

Description: Sum all node values within the inclusive range [low, high]. **Intuition:** prune branches outside the range using BST ordering.

Variables: root = current node · range [low, high] = inclusive bounds **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return 0
if root.val < low: return rangeSum(right)
if root.val > high: return rangeSum(left)
return root.val + rangeSum(left) + rangeSum(right)

```

```

class Solution {
    public int rangeSumBST(TreeNode root, int low, int high) {
        if (root == null) return 0;
        if (root.val < low) return rangeSumBST(root.right, low, high);
        if (root.val > high) return rangeSumBST(root.left, low, high);
        return root.val + rangeSumBST(root.left, low, high) + rangeSumBST(root.right, low, high);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#951 Flip Equivalent Binary Trees

Description: Check if two trees are flip-equivalent (can be made identical by swapping some children). **Intuition:** match children either directly or swapped at each node.

Variables: root1 / root2 = current nodes of the two trees **Pseudocode:**

```

if both null: return true
if one null: return false
if values differ: return false
return (match children directly) or (match children swapped)

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean flipEquiv(TreeNode root1, TreeNode root2) {
        if (root1 == null && root2 == null) return true;
        if (root1 == null || root2 == null) return false;
        if (root1.val != root2.val) return false;
        return (flipEquiv(root1.left, root2.left) && flipEquiv(root1.right, root2.right))
            || (flipEquiv(root1.left, root2.right) && flipEquiv(root1.right, root2.left));
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#958 Check Completeness of a Binary Tree

Description: Determine if a binary tree is complete. **Intuition:** BFS including null children; once a null is seen, no real node may follow.

Variables: queue = BFS queue (includes nulls) · seenNull = a gap has appeared · node = current node **Pseudocode:**

```

offer root; seenNull = false
while queue not empty:
    node = poll
    if node null: seenNull = true
    else:
        if seenNull: return false    // real node after a gap
        offer left, offer right
return true

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean isCompleteTree(TreeNode root) {
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        boolean seenNull = false;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            TreeNode node = queue.poll();
            if (node == null) {
                seenNull = true;
            } else {
                if (seenNull) return false;    // ← VARIATION: real node after a gap
                queue.offer(node.left);
                queue.offer(node.right);
            }
        }
        return true;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#987 Vertical Order Traversal of a Binary Tree

Description: Group node values by column, then by row, then by value within the same position. **Intuition:** DFS recording (col, row, val); sort by column, then row, then value.

Variables: nodes = list of {col, row, val} · prevCol = column of previous group · result = column-grouped values · dfs args row / col **Pseudocode:**

```
dfs(root, 0, 0, nodes)
sort nodes by col, then row, then val
for each node:
    if first or col changed from prevCol: start new group; prevCol = col
    add node.val to current group
return result

dfs(node, row, col):
    if null: return
    add {col, row, val}
    dfs(left, row+1, col-1); dfs(right, row+1, col+1)
```

```
class Solution {
    public List<List<Integer>> verticalTraversal(TreeNode root) {
        List<int[]> nodes = new ArrayList<>();
        dfs(root, 0, 0, nodes);
        nodes.sort((a, b) -> {
            if (a[0] != b[0]) return Integer.compare(a[0], b[0]);
            if (a[1] != b[1]) return Integer.compare(a[1], b[1]);
            return Integer.compare(a[2], b[2]);
        });
        List<List<Integer>> result = new ArrayList<>();
        Integer prevCol = null;
        for (int[] node : nodes) {
            if (prevCol == null || node[0] != prevCol) {
                result.add(new ArrayList<>());
                prevCol = node[0];
            }
            result.get(result.size() - 1).add(node[2]);
        }
        return result;
    }
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, int row, int col, List<int[]> nodes) {
        if (node == null) return;
        nodes.add(new int[]{col, row, node.val});
        dfs(node.left, row + 1, col - 1, nodes);
        dfs(node.right, row + 1, col + 1, nodes);
    }
}
```

Time $O(n \log n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#988 Smallest String Starting From Leaf

Description: Return the lexicographically smallest root-to-leaf string, where each node maps to a letter 'a'..'z' and the string is read leaf to root. **Intuition:** build the path down, reverse it at each leaf, and track the minimum.

Variables: smallest = best leaf-to-root string so far · builder = root-to-node path of letters · candidate = reversed path at a leaf **Pseudocode:**


```
dfs(root, ""); return smallest
```

```
dfs(node, builder):  
    if null: return  
    append letter ('a'+node.val)  
    if leaf:  
        candidate = reverse(builder); reverse back  
        if candidate < smallest: smallest = candidate  
    dfs(left); dfs(right)  
    delete last char
```

```
class Solution {  
    private String smallest = null;  
    public String smallestFromLeaf(TreeNode root) {  
        dfs(root, new StringBuilder());  
        return smallest;  
    }  
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, StringBuilder builder) {  
        if (node == null) return;  
        builder.append((char) ('a' + node.val));  
        if (node.left == null && node.right == null) {  
            String candidate = builder.reverse().toString();  
            builder.reverse();  
            if (smallest == null || candidate.compareTo(smallest) < 0) { smallest = candidate; }  
        }  
        dfs(node.left, builder);  
        dfs(node.right, builder);  
        builder.deleteCharAt(builder.length() - 1);  
    }  
}
```

Time $O(n \cdot h)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#993 Cousins in Binary Tree

Description: Check if two values are cousins (same depth, different parents). **Intuition:** BFS recording each value's depth and parent; cousins share depth but differ in parent.

Variables: `queue` = BFS queue · `foundX / foundY` = x/y seen this level · `x, y` = target values · `a, b` = a node's two children values **Pseudocode:**

```
offer root  
while queue not empty:  
    size = queue.size; foundX = foundY = false  
    for each node in level:  
        if node.val == x: foundX = true  
        if node.val == y: foundY = true  
        if both children exist and they are {x, y}: return false // siblings  
    offer non-null children  
    if foundX and foundY: return true  
    if foundX or foundY: return false  
return false
```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean isCousins(TreeNode root, int x, int y) {
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int size = queue.size();
            boolean foundX = false, foundY = false;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                if (node.val == x) { foundX = true; }
                if (node.val == y) { foundY = true; }
                if (node.left != null && node.right != null) {
                    int a = node.left.val, b = node.right.val;
                    if ((a == x && b == y) || (a == y && b == x)) return false; // siblings
                }
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            }
            if (foundX && foundY) return true;
            if (foundX || foundY) return false;
        }
        return false;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#998 Maximum Binary Tree II

Description: Insert a value into a maximum tree built by appending the value to the original array's end. **Intuition:** since the value was appended last, it lies on the rightmost spine; insert where it first exceeds the current node.

Variables: `root` = current node on right spine · `val` = appended value · `node` = new node when val is largest

Pseudocode:

```

if root null or val > root.val:
    node = new node(val); node.left = root; return node
root.right = insert(root.right, val)
return root

```

```

class Solution {
    public TreeNode insertIntoMaxTree(TreeNode root, int val) {
        if (root == null || val > root.val) {
            TreeNode node = new TreeNode(val);
            node.left = root;
            return node;
        }
        root.right = insertIntoMaxTree(root.right, val);
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#1008 Construct Binary Search Tree from Preorder Traversal

Description: Build a BST from its preorder traversal. **Intuition:** the first value is the root; values less than it form the left subtree, the rest form the right. Use an upper bound to decide where to stop.

Variables: `index` = pointer into preorder · `bound` = upper limit for current subtree · `root` = node built from current value **Pseudocode:**

```
return build(preorder, INT_MAX)

build(bound):
    if index == length or preorder[index] > bound: return null
    root = node(preorder[index++])
    root.left = build(root.val)
    root.right = build(bound)
    return root
```

```
class Solution {
    private int index = 0;
    public TreeNode bstFromPreorder(int[] preorder) {
        return build(preorder, Integer.MAX_VALUE);
    }
    private TreeNode build(int[] preorder, int bound) {
        if (index == preorder.length || preorder[index] > bound) return null;
        TreeNode root = new TreeNode(preorder[index++]);
        root.left = build(preorder, root.val);
        root.right = build(preorder, bound);
        return root;
    }
}
```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#1026 Maximum Difference Between Node and Ancestor

Description: Find the maximum $|a - d|$ over all ancestor a and descendant d pairs. **Intuition:** pass the min and max seen on the path down; at each node update the answer with the largest gap against those extremes.

Variables: `max` = best $|ancestor - descendant|$ found · `min` / `maxVal` = smallest/largest value on path down · `node` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```
dfs(root, root.val, root.val); return max

dfs(node, min, maxVal):
    if null: return
    max = max(max, |node.val-min|, |node.val-maxVal|)
    min = min(min, node.val); maxVal = max(maxVal, node.val)
    dfs(left, min, maxVal); dfs(right, min, maxVal)
```

```

class Solution {
    private int max = 0;
    public int maxAncestorDiff(TreeNode root) {
        dfs(root, root.val, root.val);
        return max;
    }
    private void dfs(TreeNode node, int min, int maxVal) {
        if (node == null) return;
        max = Math.max(max, Math.max(Math.abs(node.val - min), Math.abs(node.val - maxVal)));
        min = Math.min(min, node.val);
        maxVal = Math.max(maxVal, node.val);
        dfs(node.left, min, maxVal);
        dfs(node.right, min, maxVal);
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#1038 Binary Search Tree to Greater Sum Tree

Description: Replace each node's value with the sum of all values greater than or equal to it. **Intuition:** reverse inorder (right $\rightarrow$ node $\rightarrow$ left) processes descending order; carry a running sum.

Variables: `sum` = running total of values visited so far (descending) · `root` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```

if root null: return null
recurse right
sum += root.val; root.val = sum
recurse left
return root

```

```

class Solution {
    private int sum = 0;
    public TreeNode bstToGst(TreeNode root) {
        if (root == null) return null;
        bstToGst(root.right);
        sum += root.val;
        root.val = sum;
        bstToGst(root.left);
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#1087 Brace Expansion

Description: Expand a string with brace options like `{a,b}c{d,e}` into all sorted concatenations. **Intuition:** parse each position into a sorted list of choices, then backtrack the Cartesian product.

Variables: `groups` = per-position sorted choice lists · `i` = scan index over `s` · `options` = choices at one position · `builder` = current concatenation · `result` = all expansions · `start` = group index in backtrack **Pseudocode:**

```

i = 0
while i < length:
    options = []
    if s[i] == '{':
        i++; while s[i] != '}': if s[i] != ',': options.add(s[i]); i++
        i++ // skip '}'
    else: options.add(s[i]); i++
    sort options; groups.add(options)
backtrack(groups, 0, builder, result); return as array

backtrack(start, builder):
    if start == groups.size: result.add(builder); return
    for c in groups[start]:
        append c; backtrack(start+1); delete last

```

```

class Solution {
    public String[] expand(String s) {
        List<List<Character>> groups = new ArrayList<>();
        int i = 0;
        while (i < s.length()) {
            List<Character> options = new ArrayList<>();
            if (s.charAt(i) == '{') {
                i++;
                while (s.charAt(i) != '}') {
                    if (s.charAt(i) != ',') { options.add(s.charAt(i)); }
                    i++;
                }
                i++; // skip '}'
            } else {
                options.add(s.charAt(i));
                i++;
            }
            Collections.sort(options);
            groups.add(options);
        }
        List<String> result = new ArrayList<>();
        backtrack(groups, 0, new StringBuilder(), result);
        return result.toArray(new String[0]);
    }
    private void backtrack(List<List<Character>> groups, int start, StringBuilder builder, List<String> result) {
        if (start == groups.size()) { result.add(builder.toString()); return; }
        for (char c : groups.get(start)) {
            builder.append(c);
            backtrack(groups, start + 1, builder, result);
            builder.deleteCharAt(builder.length() - 1);
        }
    }
}

```

Time O(product of group sizes) | **Space** O(n)

#1104 Path In Zigzag Labelled Binary Tree

Description: Return the root-to-node path of labels in a zigzag-labeled infinite binary tree. **Intuition:** the normal parent of label is label/2, but rows alternate direction, so mirror the parent within its row range.

Variables: `level` = depth of label · `result` = root-to-label path · `levelMin / levelMax` = label range at current level ·

`label` = current node label **Pseudocode:**

```
level = floor(log2(label))
while label >= 1:
    prepend label to result
    levelMax = 2^(level+1) - 1; levelMin = 2^level
    label = (levelMin + levelMax - label) / 2    // mirror within row, then halve
    level--
return result
```

```
class Solution {
    public List<Integer> pathInZigZagTree(int label) {
        int level = 0;
        while ((1 << (level + 1)) <= label) { level++; }
        LinkedList<Integer> result = new LinkedList<>();
        while (label >= 1) {
            result.addFirst(label);
            int levelMax = (1 << (level + 1)) - 1;
            int levelMin = 1 << level;
            label = (levelMin + levelMax - label) / 2;    // ← VARIATION: mirror then halve
            level--;
        }
        return result;
    }
}
```

Time $O(\log n)$ | **Space** $O(\log n)$

#1110 Delete Nodes And Return Forest

Description: Delete the given values and return the roots of the resulting forest. **Intuition:** post-order; if a node is deleted, its surviving children become new roots. A node is a root if its parent was deleted (or it's the original root) and it itself survives.

Variables: `toDelete` = values to remove · `result` = forest roots · `isRoot` = node is a potential root (parent deleted/original root) · `deleted` = current node is to be deleted **Pseudocode:**

```
build toDelete set
if dfs(root, true, ...) != null: result.add(root)
return result

dfs(node, isRoot):
    if null: return null
    deleted = toDelete contains node.val
    if isRoot and not deleted: result.add(node)
    node.left = dfs(left, isRoot=deleted)
    node.right = dfs(right, isRoot=deleted)
    return deleted ? null : node
```

```

class Solution {
    public List<TreeNode> delNodes(TreeNode root, int[] to_delete) {
        Set<Integer> toDelete = new HashSet<>();
        for (int value : to_delete) { toDelete.add(value); }
        List<TreeNode> result = new ArrayList<>();
        if (dfs(root, true, toDelete, result) != null) { result.add(root); }
        return result;
    }
    private TreeNode dfs(TreeNode node, boolean isRoot, Set<Integer> toDelete, List<TreeNode> result) {
        if (node == null) return null;
        boolean deleted = toDelete.contains(node.val);
        if (isRoot && !deleted) { result.add(node); }
        node.left = dfs(node.left, deleted, toDelete, result);
        node.right = dfs(node.right, deleted, toDelete, result);
        return deleted ? null : node;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

Note: the helper handles adding roots; the public method's extra add is avoided by passing `isRoot` — here roots are added inside `dfs`, so the call simply discards its return.

#1123 Lowest Common Ancestor of Deepest Leaves

Description: Find the LCA of all the deepest leaves. **Intuition:** post-order return (depth, lca); when both arms reach equal depth, the node is the LCA, else carry up the deeper arm.

Variables: `Result.depth` = subtree height · `Result.node` = LCA of deepest leaves in subtree · `left / right` = child results **Pseudocode:**

```

return dfs(root).node

dfs(node):
    if null: return Result(0, null)
    left = dfs(left); right = dfs(right)
    if left.depth == right.depth: return Result(left.depth+1, node)
    return deeper side's node with depth+1

```

```

class Solution {
    public TreeNode lcaDeepestLeaves(TreeNode root) {
        return dfs(root).node;
    }
    private Result dfs(TreeNode node) {
        if (node == null) return new Result(0, null);
        Result left = dfs(node.left);
        Result right = dfs(node.right);
        if (left.depth == right.depth) {
            return new Result(left.depth + 1, node);
        }
        return left.depth > right.depth
            ? new Result(left.depth + 1, left.node)
            : new Result(right.depth + 1, right.node);
    }
    private static class Result {
        int depth;
        TreeNode node;
        Result(int depth, TreeNode node) { this.depth = depth; this.node = node; }
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(h)

#1161 Maximum Level Sum of a Binary Tree

Description: Return the 1-indexed level with the largest sum of node values. **Intuition:** BFS level by level, tracking the level whose sum is maximum.

Variables: queue = BFS queue · level = current level (1-indexed) · bestLevel = level with max sum · maxSum = best level sum · sum = current level sum **Pseudocode:**

```

offer root; level = 0; bestLevel = 1; maxSum = MIN
while queue not empty:
    level++; size = queue.size; sum = 0
    for each node in level: sum += node.val; offer non-null children
    if sum > maxSum: maxSum = sum; bestLevel = level
return bestLevel

```



```

class Solution {
    public int maxLevelSum(TreeNode root) {
        Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        int level = 0, bestLevel = 1, maxSum = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            level++;
            int size = queue.size();
            int sum = 0;
            for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
                TreeNode node = queue.poll();
                sum += node.val;
                if (node.left != null) { queue.offer(node.left); }
                if (node.right != null) { queue.offer(node.right); }
            }
            if (sum > maxSum) { maxSum = sum; bestLevel = level; }
        }
        return bestLevel;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#1214 Two Sum BSTs

Description: Given two BSTs and a target, decide if a value from each sums to the target. **Intuition:** store all values of the first BST in a set, then traverse the second checking for the complement.

Variables: `seen` = all values from tree 1 · `target` = required sum · `node` = current node **Pseudocode:**

```

collect(root1, seen)
return search(root2, target, seen)

collect(node): if null return; add val; recurse both children

search(node):
    if null: return false
    if seen contains target - node.val: return true
    return search(left) or search(right)

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean twoSumBSTs(TreeNode root1, TreeNode root2, int target) {
        Set<Integer> seen = new HashSet<>();
        collect(root1, seen);
        return search(root2, target, seen);
    }
    private void collect(TreeNode node, Set<Integer> seen) {
        if (node == null) return;
        seen.add(node.val);
        collect(node.left, seen);
        collect(node.right, seen);
    }
    private boolean search(TreeNode node, int target, Set<Integer> seen) {
        if (node == null) return false;
        if (seen.contains(target - node.val)) return true;
        return search(node.left, target, seen) || search(node.right, target, seen);
    }
}

```

Time $O(m + n)$ | **Space** $O(m)$

#1305 All Elements in Two Binary Search Trees

Description: Return all elements from two BSTs in sorted order. **Intuition:** inorder each tree into a sorted list, then merge the two lists like merge sort.

Variables: `a / b` = sorted inorder lists of the two trees · `i, j` = merge pointers into a,b · `result` = merged sorted output **Pseudocode:**

```
inorder(root1, a); inorder(root2, b)
i = j = 0
while i < a.size and j < b.size:
    add smaller of a[i], b[j]; advance that pointer
append remaining a, then remaining b
return result

inorder(node): left, add val, right
```

```
class Solution {
    public List<Integer> getAllElements(TreeNode root1, TreeNode root2) {
        List<Integer> a = new ArrayList<>(), b = new ArrayList<>();
        inorder(root1, a);
        inorder(root2, b);
        List<Integer> result = new ArrayList<>();
        int i = 0, j = 0;
        while (i < a.size() && j < b.size()) {
            if (a.get(i) <= b.get(j)) { result.add(a.get(i++)); }
            else { result.add(b.get(j++)); }
        }
        while (i < a.size()) { result.add(a.get(i++)); }
        while (j < b.size()) { result.add(b.get(j++)); }
        return result;
    }
    private void inorder(TreeNode node, List<Integer> list) {
        if (node == null) return;
        inorder(node.left, list);
        list.add(node.val);
        inorder(node.right, list);
    }
}
```

Time $O(m + n)$ | **Space** $O(m + n)$

#1361 Validate Binary Tree Nodes

Description: Given child arrays, verify the nodes form exactly one valid binary tree. **Intuition:** exactly one node has no parent (the root); every other node has exactly one parent, there are no cycles, and all nodes are reachable from the root.

Variables: `indegree[i]` = number of parents of node `i` · `root` = the unique node with indegree 0 · `queue / count` = BFS reachability count **Pseudocode:**

```

for each i: increment indegree of its children; if any exceeds 1: return false
root = -1
for each i with indegree 0: if root already set return false; root = i
if root == -1: return false
BFS from root counting reachable nodes
return count == n

```

```

class Solution {
    public boolean validateBinaryTreeNodes(int n, int[] leftChild, int[] rightChild) {
        int[] indegree = new int[n];
        for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) {
            if (leftChild[i] != -1) { if (++indegree[leftChild[i]] > 1) return false; }
            if (rightChild[i] != -1) { if (++indegree[rightChild[i]] > 1) return false; }
        }
        int root = -1;
        for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) {
            if (indegree[i] == 0) {
                if (root != -1) return false; // more than one root
                root = i;
            }
        }
        if (root == -1) return false;
        int count = 0;
        Queue<Integer> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
        queue.offer(root);
        while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
            int node = queue.poll();
            count++;
            if (leftChild[node] != -1) { queue.offer(leftChild[node]); }
            if (rightChild[node] != -1) { queue.offer(rightChild[node]); }
        }
        return count == n;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(n)$

#1382 Balance a Binary Search Tree

Description: Rebuild a BST so it becomes height-balanced. **Intuition:** inorder gives a sorted array; build a balanced BST by recursively choosing the middle element as root.

Variables: `values` = sorted inorder values · `range [lo, hi]` = subarray for current subtree · `mid` = chosen root index · `root` = built node **Pseudocode:**

```

inorder(root, values)
return build(values, 0, size-1)

inorder(node): left, add val, right

build(lo, hi):
    if lo > hi: return null
    mid = lo + (hi-lo)/2
    root = node(values[mid])
    root.left = build(lo, mid-1); root.right = build(mid+1, hi)
    return root

```

```

class Solution {
    public TreeNode balanceBST(TreeNode root) {
        List<Integer> values = new ArrayList<>();
        inorder(root, values);
        return build(values, 0, values.size() - 1);
    }
    private void inorder(TreeNode node, List<Integer> values) {
        if (node == null) return;
        inorder(node.left, values);
        values.add(node.val);
        inorder(node.right, values);
    }
    private TreeNode build(List<Integer> values, int lo, int hi) {
        if (lo > hi) return null;
        int mid = lo + (hi - lo) / 2;
        TreeNode root = new TreeNode(values.get(mid));
        root.left = build(values, lo, mid - 1);
        root.right = build(values, mid + 1, hi);
        return root;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | **Space** O(n)

#1522 Diameter of N-Ary Tree

Description: Find the diameter (longest path between any two nodes) of an N-ary tree. **Intuition:** like binary-tree diameter, but track the two deepest child heights to form the longest path through each node.

Variables: `diameter` = longest path found · `max1` / `max2` = two largest child heights · `height` = a child's height

Pseudocode:

```

dfs(root); return diameter

dfs(node):
    if null: return 0
    max1 = max2 = 0
    for each child:
        height = dfs(child)
        update max1, max2 with height (two largest)
    diameter = max(diameter, max1 + max2)
    return max1 + 1

```

```

class Solution {
    private int diameter = 0;
    public int diameter(Node root) {
        dfs(root);
        return diameter;
    }
    private int dfs(Node node) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        int max1 = 0, max2 = 0;
        for (Node child : node.children) {
            int height = dfs(child);
            if (height > max1) { max2 = max1; max1 = height; }
            else if (height > max2) { max2 = height; }
        }
        diameter = Math.max(diameter, max1 + max2);
        return max1 + 1;
    }
}

```

Time O(n) | Space O(h)

#1644 Lowest Common Ancestor of a Binary Tree II

Description: Find the LCA of two nodes that may not both exist in the tree; return null if either is missing. **Intuition:** standard LCA but count how many of p, q were actually found, so a node returned without seeing both isn't accepted.

Variables: `found` = count of p/q actually present · `lca` = candidate LCA from dfs · `left / right` = recursive results

Pseudocode:

```

lca = dfs(root, p, q)
return found == 2 ? lca : null

dfs(node):
    if null: return null
    left = dfs(left); right = dfs(right)
    if node == p or node == q: found++; return node
    if left and right both non-null: return node
    return left != null ? left : right

```

```

class Solution {
    private int found = 0;
    public TreeNode lowestCommonAncestor(TreeNode root, TreeNode p, TreeNode q) {
        TreeNode lca = dfs(root, p, q);
        return found == 2 ? lca : null;
    }
    private TreeNode dfs(TreeNode node, TreeNode p, TreeNode q) {
        if (node == null) return null;
        TreeNode left = dfs(node.left, p, q);
        TreeNode right = dfs(node.right, p, q);
        if (node == p || node == q) {
            found++;
            return node;
        }
        if (left != null && right != null) return node;
        return left != null ? left : right;
    }
}

```

Time $O(n)$ | **Space** $O(h)$

#1650 Lowest Common Ancestor of a Binary Tree III

Description: Find the LCA of two nodes given parent pointers, without root access. **Intuition:** like finding the intersection of two linked lists — walk both pointers up, switching to the other node when one reaches the top; they meet at the LCA.

Variables: `a` / `b` = two pointers walking up from `p` and `q`, switching to the other's start at the top **Pseudocode:**

```
a = p; b = q
while a != b:
    a = (a == null) ? q : a.parent
    b = (b == null) ? p : b.parent
return a
```

```
class Solution {
    public Node lowestCommonAncestor(Node p, Node q) {
        Node a = p, b = q;
        while (a != b) {
            a = a == null ? q : a.parent;
            b = b == null ? p : b.parent;
        }
        return a;
    }
}
```

Time $O(h)$ | **Space** $O(1)$